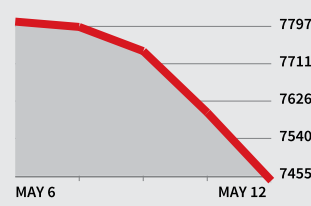


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 74559.24 (-1456.04)

IN FOCUS



	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23379.55	-436.30
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.17	-0.39
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.62	+0.31
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	151025.00	+1265
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	264867.00	+8667

GAINING MOMENTUM.

Expect healthy rise in savings, retail term deposits in coming quarters, says Canara Bank CEO Hardeep Singh Ahluwalia **p7**



NO ATF RELIEF.

Air India looks to suspend flights to key international destinations till August **p12**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

April retail inflation hits 14-month high of 3.48%

COST PUSH. Higher prices of food, gold and silver were key drivers

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Driven by a sustained rally in gold and silver prices, retail inflation accelerated for the sixth consecutive month to a 14-month high 3.48 per cent in April. Yet, the print remains comfortably below the RBI's 4 per cent target, strengthening the case for the central bank to maintain a *status quo* on interest rates. The inflation rate was 3.4 per cent in March.

Food inflation, a key constituent of the Consumer Price Index, hit 4.2 per cent in April, up from 3.87 per cent in March. The inflation rate for silver jewellery, and gold/diamond/platinum jewellery was over 144 per cent and 40 per cent, respectively, in April.

CORE INFLATION

According to Rajeev Sharan, Head of Research at Brickwork Ratings, core inflation at 3.3 per cent remains relatively contained, with categories such as housing (2.15 per cent), health (1.64 per cent), household goods (1.61 per cent), and several non-food categories showing moderate price momentum.

Mixed basket

Low inflation

-19	Potato
-23.7	Onion
-6.9	Motor car/Jeep
-7.1	Peas
-7.9	chickpeas
-6.8	Air conditioner
-5.8	
-5.1	

Sources: MoSPI

High inflation

148.4	Silver jewellery
144.3	Cocunut: copra
45.5	Gold/Diamond/Platinum Jewellery
44.5	Tomato
45.9	
40.7	
36.0	
35.3	
34.2	
25.6	

Yet, this softness may prove fragile if higher logistics and input costs, already visible in fertilizer market, spill over into non-food segments, he said.

HDFC Bank Principal Economist Sakshi Gupta said that while April's headline figure offers the RBI a favourable starting point amid global headwinds, rising oil prices remain a critical risk.

With crude hovering above \$100/barrel, Gupta warned that an increase in pump prices would exert direct and indirect pressure on inflation. Specifically, she estimated that a ₹5 rise in petrol could spark a 20bps rise in inflation through direct impact alone.

Economists also see inflation inching up further. "Ind-Ra sees the headline inflation rising to 3.6 per cent in May in case of no pass-through of high energy rates to consumers as also due to gold and silver prices," said Megha Arora, Director, India Ratings & Research.

All eyes are now on the Monetary Policy Committee, which will meet early next month. "We expect the RBI to remain on a wait-and-watch mode to assess the pass-through of the risks. However, the risks for early rate hikes (perhaps from October) are building up," said Upasna Bhardwaj, Chief Economist at Kotak Mahindra Bank.

Crude spike sparks ₹, market rout; investors lose \$115 billion

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Markets took a severe beating on Tuesday, hammered by a mix of surging crude oil prices on no signs of any deal between Iran and US, a freefall of the rupee and unrelenting selling by foreign portfolio investors.

Around \$115 billion in market wealth was wiped out as equity benchmarks recorded their steepest one-day fall in six weeks and in the broader markets all sectors closed in the red.

The rupee sank to a record low as foreign portfolio investors sold over ₹2-lakh crore worth shares in 2026. In May alone, they sold shares for ₹17,000 crore.

According to analysts, after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's austerity call, Founder and Director of Kotak Mahindra Bank Uday Kotak warning that the global economy is on the verge of a significant "shock" also sullied sentiment further.

SENSEX, NIFTY TUMBLE

The Nifty 50 closed at 23,379.55, down 436.30 points or 1.83 per cent, while the Sensex shed 1,456 points or 1.92 per cent to settle below the 75,000-mark at 74,559.24.

Under pressure

	Close	Fall (Pts & %)
Nifty	23,379.55	-436.3 (-1.83)
Sensex	74,559.2	-1,456.04 (-1.92)
Nifty Next50	68,586.6	-1,711.3 (-2.43)
Nifty Bank	53,555.2	-884.7 (-1.63)
Nifty IT	28,234.9	-1,094.55 (-3.73)
Nifty Midcap100	59,704.7	-1,553.75 (-2.54)
Nifty SmallCap100	17,939.0	-586.8 (-3.17)
Nifty Cons.Dur	34,633.9	-1,290.05 (-3.59)
Nifty Realty	765.7	-32.8 (-4.11)

On sell mode

	FPIs (₹ crore)
May 4	2,969.02
May 5	-3,399.03
May 6	-5,697.61
May 7	-69.31
May 8	-1,392.18
May 11	-7,827.78
May 12	-1,959.39

The broader market fared even worse — Nifty Midcap 100 fell 2.54 per cent and Nifty Smallcap 100 tumbled 3.17 per cent, reflecting widespread risk aversion well beyond blue-chip counters. The market breadth was heavily skewed, with 463 of the Nifty 500 stocks closing in the red. Fuelling the rout was Brent crude, which climbed above \$107 a barrel as stalled US-Iran negotiations kept supply disruption fears firmly alive.

The rupee bore the brunt of this anxiety, sinking to a record low. The Indian currency closed 31 paise down at an all-time low of 95.6275 per US dollar.

Intraday, it fell to a record low 95.7375/dollar, surpassing the previous low of

95.4325. The central bank is believed to have intervened, leading to a pull back in the rupee. "The joker in the pack right now is crude oil. If it cools, we can see Indian markets bouncing back," said Kranthi Bathini, Director of Equity Strategy, WealthMills Securities.

OPENAI SPOOKS IT

IT stocks were the session's biggest casualty, with Nifty IT declining nearly 4 per cent and slumping to a 3-year low spooked by OpenAI's announcement of "The Deployment Company", a new enterprise AI implementation unit backed by the acquisition of consulting firm Tomoro. Infosys, TCS, HCLTech and TechM were among the hardest hit.

West Asia war: Uday Kotak, CEA warn of massive 'shock'

Our Bureau
New Delhi

India is facing a "live balance of payments stress test" as the West Asia conflict threatens to disrupt critical energy corridors, warned Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran and veteran banker Uday Kotak, adding that while the country has navigated the crisis effectively so far, the "buffer era" for energy prices is nearing its end.

"The impact is coming, and

it's coming big," Kotak cautioned at the CII Annual Business Summit, noting that oil companies can no longer act as shock absorbers. "The oil shock is coming. We had the ability for oil companies to be the shock absorber, and it's a large amount of money. I don't think we're very far away from the shock," Kotak said. "The West Asia crisis is not just a foreign policy concern; it is a live macroeconomic imperative for FY27," Nageswaran stated.

Also read p3

'Losses of OMCs may hit ₹1-lakh cr'

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri on Tuesday said that India has sufficient supplies of petrol, diesel and cooking gas despite the on-going disruptions around the Strait of Hormuz adding that India has ramped up produc-

tion of domestic LPG. However, he expressed concern over the fiscal stress of oil marketing companies losing ₹1,000 crore per day with projected cumulative losses of as much as ₹1-lakh crore in a single quarter if elevated crude prices persist and retail fuel prices remain unchanged.

Details p3

NEET test cancelled, new dates soon

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The medical entrance test — NEET (UG) 2026 — held on May 3 was cancelled by the government on Tuesday amid allegations of paper

leak and the CBI registering an FIR. Even as the government said fresh dates would be notified in the next 7-10 days, Congress and other Opposition parties came down on the paper leak and demanded accountability.

Details p12

TOYOTA PRESENTS **DRUM TAO**

LIVE THE *Awesome* BEAT
DRIVE TO PLAY

HEV

LOW RATE OF INTEREST
@ 4.99%* | COMPLIMENTARY 5-YEAR
ROADSIDE ASSISTANCE AND WARRANTY* | ATTRACTIVE
EXCHANGE BENEFITS*

* Finance at the sole discretion of Toyota Financial Services India Ltd. Scheme offers valid till 31st May, 2026. Digitally created visual. Picture of vehicle was not taken while driving. *T&C apply.

ALL NEW **CAMRY**

SPORTY CONFIDENT
Awesome

LAND CRUISER 300 VELLFIRE CAMRY LEGENDER FORTUNER HILUX INNOVA HYCROSS INNOVA CRYSTA HYYDER RUMION URBAN CRUISER TAISOR GLANZA

TAMIL NADU: Chennai: Epic Toyota (Anna Salai, Vyasarpadi) Ph: 9500007575; Harsha Toyota (Avadi, Gummidipundi Guindy, Madhavaram, Pallavaram, Poonamallee, Thiruvallur) Ph: 044-39997999, 9677056789; Lanson Toyota (Ambattur) Ph: 044-40008000; Lanson Toyota (Cenotaph Road) Ph: 044-40008000, 9841290100; Lanson Toyota (Koyambedu) Ph: 044-40008000, 9551064600; Lanson Toyota (Nandanam) Ph: 044-40008000; Lanson Toyota (Neelankarai) Ph: 044-40008000, 9710922974; Lanson Toyota (Velachery) Ph: 044-40008000, 9551285070; Arani: Lanson Toyota Ph: 044-40008000, 9698330303; Ariyalur: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 7373054200; Bhavani: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9578499100; Chengalpeta: Krish Toyota, Pullipakkam, Ph: 9840665577; Coimbatore: Anaamalais Toyota, Ph: 6385733700; Krish Toyota, Ph: 9087355577; Dharapuram: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 7305998600; Dharmapuri: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9688995400; Dindigul: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9524099300, 9095299800; Erode: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9842296700; Gingee: Lanson Toyota Ph: 044-40008000, 9942533800; Gobichettipalayam: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 7305948700; Hosur: Akashkrish Toyota Ph: 04344 294 888, 9363401713; Kanchipuram: Lanson Toyota Ph: 044-40008000, 9976730303; Kangayam: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9524844700; Karaikal: Lanson Toyota Ph: 044-40008000, 9095269000; Karur: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9578137600; Kumbakonam: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 7373013700, 9865815700; Madhampatti: Anaamalais Toyota, Ph: 9965531600, Madurai: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9976855500, 9865224800; Mannargudi: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 7845103600; Marthandam: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9976433700, 8122829700; Mettupalayam: Anaamalais Toyota, Ph: 9965933100; Nagercoil: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9965547600; Ramnad: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9600981900, 8012799000; Ranipet: Lanson Toyota Ph: 044-40008000, 997673030; Salem: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 971599300, 9688831600; Sriperumbudur: Lanson Toyota Ph: 044-40008000; Tanjore: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9578653700; Thiruvannamalai: Lanson Toyota Ph: 044-40008000, 9698330303; Tirupattur: Lanson Toyota Ph: 044-40008000, 9842340100; Tirunelveli: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9688065300, 9524133700; Tirupur: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 7373752700; Tuticorin: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9629525600, 7373065300; Trichy: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9965426300, 9788754200; Udumalpet: Anaamalais Toyota Ph: 9095911900; Villore: Lanson Toyota Ph: 044-40008000, 7550100111; Villupuram: Lanson Toyota Ph: 044-40008000, 9585527900; PONDICHERRY: Lanson Toyota Ph: 044-40008000, 9585514500.

QUICKLY.

Adani Power gets CCI nod to acquire GVK Energy



New Delhi: Trade regulator CCI on Tuesday approved billionaire Gautam Adani-led Adani Power Ltd's proposal to acquire GVK Energy. GVK Energy Ltd, through its subsidiary AHPL, is engaged in the generation of power from a 330 MW hydroelectric power project in Srinagar, Uttarakhand. "CCI approves acquisition of 100 per cent share capital of GVK Energy Ltd by Adani Power Ltd," the regulator said in a post on X. [PTI](#)

Tata Chemicals CEO takes over as CII president

New Delhi: Tata Chemicals MD and CEO R Mukundan has assumed office as the Confederation of Indian Industry president for 2026-27, the industry body said on Tuesday. He takes over from Rajiv Memani. Suchitra K Ella, co-founder and MD of Bharat Biotech, takes over as CII President-Designate for 2026-27. [PTI](#)

Notice disputes 1989 transfer of Tata Sons shares to Naval Tata

POINT OF CONTENTION. 'No trustee resolution approving the transfer of 833 shares'

Our Bureau
Mumbai

A legal notice has been sent to senior trustees and executives associated with the Tata group alleging that the transfer of valuable Tata Sons shares from a charitable trust to late industrialist Naval H Tata in 1989 was unlawful and amounted to a breach of fiduciary duty. The notice, dated May 12 and issued by advocate Katayani Agrawal on behalf of the complainant Sunil Tulsiram Patilkhede, has been addressed to senior executives like Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata; Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran; Tata Trusts Vice-Chairman Venu Srinivasan; Tata Trusts CEO Siddharth Sharma, and trustees Vijay Singh, Jehangir C Jehangir, Darius Khambata, Neville Tata and Bhaskar Bhat. The current legal notice pertains to the Navajbai Ratan Tata Trust (NR Tata Trust), a public charitable trust established by Ratan Tata in 1974, in which Ratan



Naval H Tata

Tata and Nani Palkivala were the initial trustees. Subsequently, Naval Hormusji Tata was also added as a trustee. According to the notice, the Sir Ratan Tata Trust transferred 625 equity shares and 34 preference shares of Tata Sons to the NR Tata Trust in December 1974 as a corpus donation. At that time, the book value of the shares and preference shares were recorded at ₹7.8 lakh. The notice states that following a bonus issue, the NR Tata Trust's equity holding increased to 833 shares. It alleges that after Naval H Tata resigned as trustee of the NR

Senior executives like Noel Tata, Venu Srinivasan, N Chandrasekaran, among those issued notices

Tata Trust in January 1989, the 833 shares were transferred to him personally on January 18, 1989, for "nil" consideration. According to sources, those shares are now allegedly worth several thousand crores of rupees. 'INVALID TRANSFER' The complainant has alleged that there was no trustee resolution approving the transfer and no valid transfer deed or statutory documentation executed under Section 108 of the Companies Act, 1956. The notice further claims that the shares, which constituted trust property, were transferred at below fair value and without any demonstrated benefit to the charitable trust. The notice contends that the transaction amounted to

a breach of fiduciary duty and breach of trust and therefore constituted a "void transaction and a nullity". It further notes that after Naval Tata's death in May 1989, the shares were transferred in 1993 to his successors — Simone Tata, Ratan Tata, Jimmy Tata and Noel Tata. According to the notice, "a transfer of shares by a trust to an ex-trustee in his individual and proprietary capacity, without fair value, is a classic case of breach of fiduciary duty and breach of trust," and "the transaction fails to explain the objective of the transfer and how it assisted in achieving the objectives and purpose of the NR Tata Trust. The notice has given the recipients 15 days to "make good the loss", failing which it has threatened civil and criminal proceedings. There was no response to emails sent to all the trustees named in the notice. This notice comes just days ahead of a meeting of Tata Trusts on May 16, originally scheduled for last week but called off without a reason.

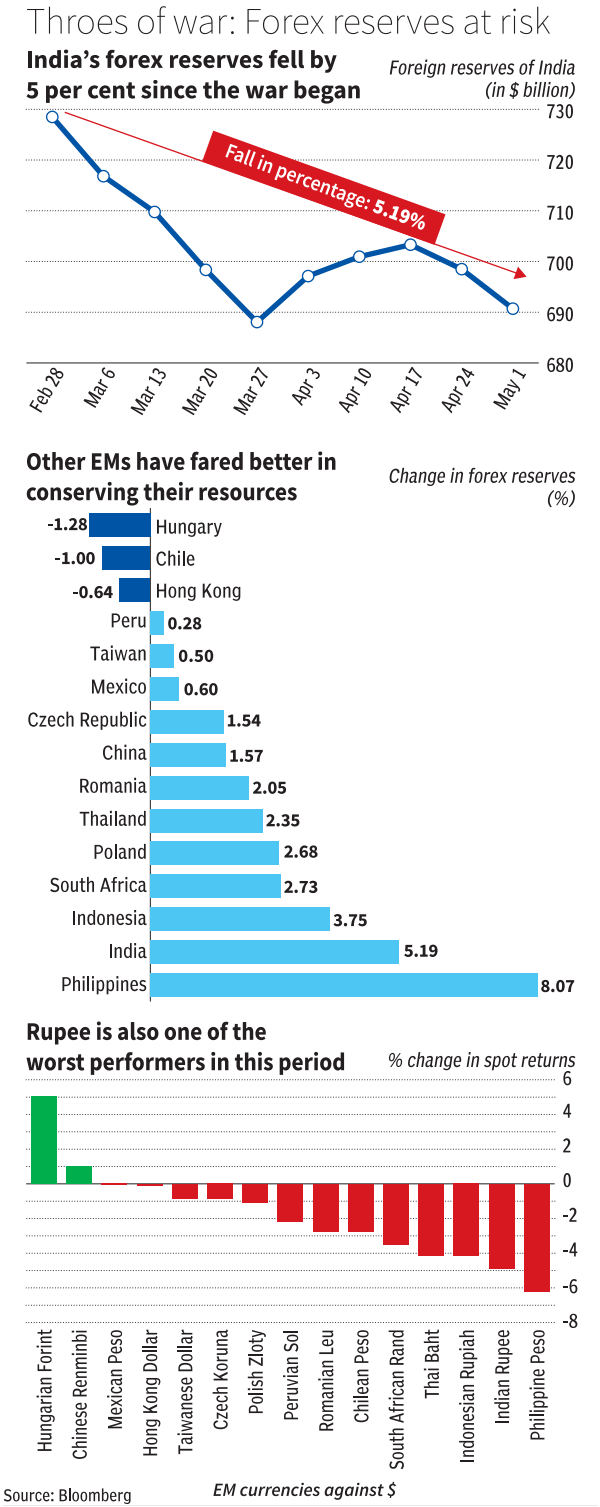
Forex reserves shrink 5% since March, one of the highest among oil importing EMs

**Sourashis Banerjee
Aleena Rose Jose
Anu Keerthana**
Chennai

The rupee fell 32 paise to touch 95.6275 against the dollar on Tuesday as rising crude oil prices sent the Indian currency to its life-time low. The Indian currency has been one of the worst affected among EM currencies due to the country's high dependence on crude oil imports. The RBI's efforts to buttress the rupee has resulted in 5.2 per cent depletion in India's foreign exchange reserves, which is one of the highest among net oil importing emerging economies.

DATA FOCUS.

businessline analysis finds that India's forex reserves fell from \$728.5 billion to \$690.7 billion between February 27 and May 1 of 2026. In comparison to this, Hungary and Chile, both highly dependent on imported energy, saw their forex reserves increase by 1.3 per cent and 1 per cent, respectively. Meanwhile, countries like Peru and Taiwan registered modest losses in reserves during the same period, as their high value exports somewhat balance the rising import costs.



At ₹1.98-lakh crore, PSBs net record high profits in FY26

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Public sector banks (PSBs) have achieved an all-time high profit of ₹1.98 lakh crore during fiscal year 2025-26 (FY26), Finance Ministry said on Tuesday. This is over 11 per cent higher than ₹1.78 lakh crore of FY25. "Improved asset quality, healthy credit expansion and higher income contributed to improved profitability of PSBs during 2025-26," the Ministry said in a statement. It added that PSBs continued to register strong financial performance reflecting sustained business growth, improved asset quality, record profitability and strong cap-

ital position. As on date, there are 12 PSBs in India. Aggregate operating profit reached ₹3.21 lakh crore, while aggregate net profit increased by 11.1 per cent y-o-y to a historic high of ₹1.98 lakh crore, marking the fourth consecutive year of aggregate profitability for PSBs. The aggregate business of PSBs increased to ₹283.3 lakh crore as on March 31, 2026, registering growth of 12.8 per cent over the previous year. **DEPOSITS & ASSETS** Aggregate deposits rose 10.6 per cent y-o-y to ₹156.3 lakh crore, reflecting continued depositor confidence and strong resource mobilisation

by PSBs. Gross advances grew 15.7 per cent y-o-y at ₹127 lakh crore. Asset quality of PSBs improved significantly during FY26, with gross NPA ratio (non-perfuming assets) declining to 1.93 per cent and net NPA ratio to 0.39 per cent as on March 31, 2026, reflecting historically low levels of stressed assets. Further, each PSB maintained provisioning coverage ratio of above 90 per cent, indicating prudent provisioning practices, improved underwriting standards, effective risk management mechanisms and strengthened balance sheet resilience, the Ministry said. Fresh slippages continued to decline during FY26, with



slippage ratio reducing to 0.7 per cent. Total recoveries, including recoveries from written-off accounts, stood at ₹86,971 crore, reflecting improved recovery mechanisms and better credit discipline across PSBs. The continued improvement in the performance of PSBs reflects the resilience

of the Indian economy and the government's sustained reforms aimed at strengthening the banking sector through improved governance, technology adoption, enhanced credit discipline and wider access to formal credit. These measures have contributed to lower stressed assets, improved operational efficiency and stronger financial position of PSBs, the Ministry said. "Today, PSBs are well-capitalised, profitable and institutionally stronger, enabling them to effectively support India's growth aspirations and contribute meaningfully towards the vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047," the Ministry concluded.

Tractor sector saw 27% jump in sales in April on strong rural sentiment

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai



Domestic tractor industry opened FY27 on a strong note, with wholesale rising 27 per cent year-on-year to 1,05,021 units in April, against 82,839 units in the same month last year, aided by favourable farm sentiment, improved rural liquidity and lower GST rates. According to data from the Tractor and Mechanization Association (TMA), this is the second consecutive month that domestic tractor sales have crossed the one lakh mark. Domestic sales stood at 1,03,193 units in March 2026 before increasing further in April.

According to Crisil Ratings, GST reduction continues to support affordability and sustain near-term demand momentum. **GST PUSH** Poonam Upadhyay, Director, Crisil Ratings, said India's tractor industry opened FY27 on an encouraging

note. The GST reduction on tractors from 12 per cent to 5 per cent continues to support affordability and is likely playing a role in sustaining near-term demand. However, the high base built over FY26, which was a record year driven by a favourable monsoon and strong farm incomes, will make comparisons progressively harder as the year progresses, she told *businessline*. The IMD has projected 2026 southwest monsoon at 92 per cent of the Long Period Average, with possible El Niño conditions raising concerns over kharif sowing. How the rest of FY27 shapes up will depend largely on monsoon distribution and crop output, she added.

Sales slump in US drags Dr Reddy's Q4 profit by 86% to ₹220 cr

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Dr Reddy's Laboratories' consolidated net profit declined 86 per cent at ₹220 crore in the fourth quarter of the last financial year ended March 31, 2026, compared to ₹1,593 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous year. The total revenue of the Hyderabad-based company decreased 12 per cent at ₹7,516 crore in the quarter under review against ₹8,506 crore in the year-ago period. In a press conference on Tuesday, M V Narasimham, CFO, Dr Reddy's, attributed decline in revenue and net profit to lower lenalidomide (generic Revlimid) sales in the US and some specific items which were one-offs.

Weak health			
	Q4 FY25	Q4 FY26	Change (%)
Revenue	8,506	7,516	-12
Selling, general, admin expenses	2,405	2,776	15
Net profit	1,587	220	-86

The results include the adverse impact of a Shelf Stock Adjustment (SSA) related to lenalidomide of ₹453 crore, impairment of CAR-T assets and Eftilagimod Alfa of a total of ₹228 crore and provisions related to VAT liability of ₹ 114 crore. Additionally, FY26 also included the adverse impact of VAT liability provision of ₹69 crore and ₹117 crore for New Labour Codes, the CFO said. Revenue from North America declined 51 per cent at ₹1,756 crore while the same from Europe, India and

emerging markets grew 14 per cent, 20 per cent and 29 per cent, respectively. For the full year, total revenue increased 3 per cent at ₹33,593 crore even as the net profit declined 24 per cent at ₹4,285 crore. **SEMAGLUTIDE** Dr Reddy's is betting big on Semaglutide generic. It received the Notice of Compliance from the Pharmaceutical Drugs Directorate for generic Semaglutide injection in Canada, indicated for treatment of Type 2 dia-

betes. "We will be launching the drug in Canada over the next few days," said Erez Israeli, CEO, Dr Reddy's, adding that the company had adequate capacity to cater to the market needs in Canada. Beyond Canada, it has already filed for approvals in multiple geographies and would launch the generic after approvals, according to Deepak Sapra, CEO - API & Services. "Semaglutide is a vehicle for us to enter GLP space and the Canadian approval validates our capabilities," Sapra said. Dr Reddy's, which received approval for the oral Semaglutide in India, will soon launch it in the domestic market at a "competitive" price, he added. It has already launched generic Semaglutide Injection in India for treatment of Type 2 diabetes, under the brand 'Obeda' on the first day of market formation post loss of exclusivity in March. During Q4, it also forayed into hormone replacement therapy in India with acquisition of Progynova and related assets and received acceptance for review by the United States Food and Drug Administration (USFDA) of Biologics License Application (BLA) for Intravenous (IV) presentation of abatacept biosimilar in the US. **PLAN AHEAD** Dr Reddy's plans to invest ₹2,000 crore in the capex in the current financial year and will also scout for suitable acquisitions as it had a net cash surplus of ₹3,271 crore. The board recommended a dividend of ₹8 per equity share of face value of ₹1 each for FY26.

Maruti to back 6 start-ups for AI-based solutions

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Maruti Suzuki India Ltd (MSIL) on Tuesday said it has selected six start-ups from the 10th Cohort of its flagship Accelerator Program. They have been awarded paid Proof of Concepts (PoCs) to co-create artificial intelligence (AI)-based and

technology-led solutions with the company. The six start-ups include Goat Robotics, SheerDrive, Schijnenn Digital, GenbaNEXT, Swayatt Drishtigochar and Swiftex. The solutions aim to further improve safety and efficiency in plant operations, reduce product development time, strengthen material-level traceability, and further enhance customer experience, MSIL said. "The solutions that we are co-creating with these start-ups will enable us to further improve safety in our plants, help reduce product design and development lead time, strengthen material traceability to support our circularity efforts," said Hisashi Takeuchi, MD and CEO, MSIL.

RIL's Mappedu Logistics Park is Chennai Global Logistics Park

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Reliance Industries' ambitious multi-modal logistics park project at Mappedu near Chennai has been renamed Chennai Global Logistics Park Ltd, with Dubai-based DP World onboarded as a joint venture partner, multiple sources said. According to sources, the Dubai-based shipping major has taken around two lakh sq ft of warehousing space within the logistics park and has acquired a 49 per cent stake in the joint venture. Both companies declined to comment on the development. The logistics park currently has five warehouses.

Tata Power Q4 revenue dips 12.8 % on Mundra unit closure; RE, T&D limit loss

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Tata Power on Tuesday saw a fall in revenue in Q4 of FY26, due to its Mundra Power plant remaining closed during the quarter, though strong execution across renewables, transmission and distribution helped offset the decline to some extent. The company reported 12.8 per cent fall in revenue from operations to ₹14,900 crore, while net profit fell 4.5 per cent to ₹996 crore. The company had supplied power from the Mundra plant up to June 30, 2025, based on the directions of the Ministry of Power. From July 3, the plant's operations were suspended to resolve technical issues.



Operationally, the quarter was driven by the continued ramp-up of clean energy assets, solar manufacturing and distribution gains, with the core business delivering 13 per cent PAT growth in Q4. The company said EBITDA rose 10 per cent to ₹4,216 crore. Its renewable business posted PAT of ₹406 crore in the quarter and ₹1,994 crore

for the year, up 59 per cent, supported by higher capacity additions and strong execution in solar manufacturing and rooftop solar. **SOLAR PV, OTHERS** The company said its solar cell and module manufacturing arm reported PAT of ₹265 crore in Q4 and ₹857 crore in FY26, helped by an industry-leading yield of over 95 per cent. In transmission and distribution, PAT came in at ₹949 crore in Q4 and ₹2,978 crore in FY26, up 54 per cent and 49 per cent respectively, while Odisha DISCOMs posted PAT of ₹304 crore in the quarter and ₹809 crore for the year. Tata Power said its transmission portfolio now stands at 7,403 ckm.

Adani Ports enters Europe offshore services market

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd. (APSEZ) has entered the European offshore services market through its marine arm Astro Offshore, partnering US-based Oceaneering International Inc. to pursue underwater and deep-sea projects in the region. The move marks a significant overseas expansion for APSEZ's fast-growing marine business as it seeks to reduce geographic concentration risks and expand beyond its existing presence across West Asia, North Africa and West Africa. The development comes days after *businessline* reported on May 6 that APSEZ was redesigning

its offshore marine strategy following disruptions linked to tensions in West Asia and evaluating opportunities to expand into Europe. Under the partnership, Astro Offshore will combine its fleet capabilities with Oceaneering's deepwater engineering expertise to target offshore projects such as underwater construction, cable laying and pipeline installation in European markets. "This development supports APSEZ's ambition to build a globally diversified marine platform," stated Ashwani Gupta, whole-time director and chief executive officer of APSEZ. Astro Offshore has added a new vessel — Energy Savannah, which will be renamed Astro Atlas — to strengthen its offshore capabilities.

businessline.

Disclaimer: Readers are requested to verify & make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THE PUBLISHING: PVT LTD., the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser's products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/liable in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

Poison in the food

India needs cogent policy to regulate pesticide use

The Centre must quickly follow up on its intent to impose a nationwide ban on paraquat dichloride, a herbicide or weedicide which has been linked to kidney failure, lung fibrosis and Parkinson’s disease. As reported by this newspaper, Telangana has banned paraquat with effect from April, but the ban cannot be pushed beyond a couple of months under the present set of laws.



While there seems to be ample medical evidence to establish the toxicity of paraquat, the onus is now on the Centre to take the matter forward. A ‘Registration Committee’ will presumably decide on whether the ban should be enforced for longer period. Under the proposed Pesticides Management Bill, 2025, which also looks into the illegal sale of pesticides and the regulatory systems needed, the Centre or States can enforce a ban for a year. The Committee will then review the pesticide over a year and take a call. The growing application of pesticides — herbicides, weedicides and insecticides — is explained by several factors. They are used more in irrigated areas where the cost of cultivation, and therefore, of any crop loss, is high. Changing monsoon patterns, particularly dry spells, might have contributed to increased pesticide use. Contract farming in horticulture, where certain quantities have to be supplied regardless of the situation, too leads to increased use of such inputs. The absence of labour or machines to take care of weeds works as a factor. Finally, incorrect application of fertilizer, such as uneven broadcasting of urea in paddy, also invites pest attacks.

The policy challenge here is two-fold: first, curtailing the production and sale of lethal pesticides, and establishing liability in the event of damage; and second, promoting a range of cropping techniques — besides less input-intensive crops — in order to deal with the challenge of pest attacks. State governments and agri universities are evolving sustainable agriculture practices that promote soil and plant health. The Tamil Nadu Agriculture University has been working on integrated weed management, which entails using mechanical, biological and permissible chemical methods instead of weedicides such as paraquat or glyphosate (banned for being carcinogenic, but circulated freely). It recommends hand weeding, inter-cultivation, crop rotation, mulching, flooding in rice fields and prudent use of safer herbicides. In the case of millets and pulses, inter-cropping and hand weeding a month after sowing is effective. Organisms such as Mexican beetle are effective against weeds.

A shift away from intensive cultivation of paddy and wheat (paddy accounts for a lion’s share of pesticides use) and towards millets and pulses will do soil and plant health some good. Crucially, traditional varieties of rice should be promoted. Detoxifying agriculture is not about going ‘organic’ — but about creating a bouquet of applications.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH



Decoding banks’ return to health

TAKING STOCK. Model of debt induced consumption led growth is not sustainable for long. It is subject to income shocks



C RANGARAJAN
B SAMBAMURTHY

The banking landscape in 2025 is significantly different from what it was a decade ago. It is marked by consolidation of public sector banks and regional rural banks. New category of banks like small finance banks (SFBs) and payment banks (PBs) were licensed so as to deepen financial inclusion. Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) added a transformative layer for distribution of financial services.

Twelve operative SFBs account for only 1.4 per cent of the commercial banks’ business. PBs’ business model is narrower than what is considered as narrow banking.

They are not permitted to lend and can accept deposits only up to a maximum of ₹2 lakh per customer and that too only as savings or current account. The PBs deployed nearly a million business correspondents to serve in the villages. Many experts question the relevance and viability of PBs, given the huge success of UPI.

Not surprisingly PBs aspire to become SFBs and the latter aspire to graduate to universal banks to improve profitability.

EMERGENCE OF FINTECHS, DPI
DPI democratised access to finance with private sector innovation on the top of public infra. UPI is the most visible and impactful innovation in recent times and this real time mobile payment system clocked over 220 billion transactions.

Aadhaar enabled payment system (Aeps) provided digital assisted payment system to over 95 per cent of six lakh villages through micro ATMs.

Open Credit Enabled Network (OCEN), Account Aggregators (AAs), Unified Lending Interface (ULI), fintechs, over thousand lending apps, and UPI have created a new digital ecosystem for small ticket loans. Loans are available at the push of a button in minutes and seconds. But speed at the cost of underwriting quality creates stress in loan portfolios and also over-leverage by small borrowers. The aggregate net profit of

TABLE 1				
Performance parameters				
Parameter	2015	2018	(in %)	
Capital adequacy ratio (CRAR)	12.9	13.8	16.0	
Return on equity (ROE)	10.4	-0.5	13.0	
Return on assets (ROA)	0.8	-2.8	1.4	
Gross NPA (%)	7.5	11.2	2.2	
Net NPA (%)	4.4	6.0	0.5	
Provision coverage ratio (%)	61.0	48.0	75.0	
Net interest margin (NIM)	2.6	2.5	3.1	
Credit-deposit ratio (%)	78.0	74.0	80.0	

TABLE 2				
Composition of credit				
	2015	2025	(all figures in ₹ lakh crore)	
			Absolute increase	% increase
Credit	62	190	128	206
Personal	13	62	49	370
Services	14	52	38	270
Agri	8	19	11	137
Industry	26	41	15	57
Large industry	21	27	6	28
Infrastructure	10	13	3	30

commercial banks increased 14-fold to ₹3.7 lakh crore in 2025. There is an all-round improvement in the various financial parameters such as Return on Assets, NPAs and Capital Adequacy Ratio (see Table 1)

CRITICAL ISSUES
Government’s infusion of growth and regulatory capital of about ₹3 lakh crore, and resolution of NPAs helped achieve this turnaround. This turnaround notwithstanding, some critical issues need attention to sustain growth, stability and inclusion and these are discussed below.

Declining share of bank deposits:
The share of bank deposits in the household financial savings has been on the decline from 41 per cent in 2016 to 35 per cent in 2025. The share of market

Housing loans which account for 50 per cent of personal segment need a reality check, though they are classified as secured

linked products like equity, mutual funds has shown significant increase from less than 1 per cent in 2016 to nearly 15.5 per cent in 2025. It is claimed that while aggregate saving may not be a function of interest rate, its distribution among different forms may be influenced by interest rate. Policymakers need to keep this in mind while deciding on the level of interest rate and fiscal incentives.

It is important to note that loans create deposits which remain in the system. But expansion of credit is constrained by capital adequacy and reserve requirements. There is a difference between the macro conception of deposit growth and micro conception of deposit growth that is from the point of view of banks. While overall deposit growth is influenced by reserve money creation and reserve requirement, banks need to pay a close look at fixed deposit growth which is influenced by interest rate.

Alignment of credit growth rate to nominal GDP growth rate: Credit growth rate far in excess of expected nominal GDP growth rate is not sustainable and even counterproductive

A silent casualty of market chaos

Geopolitical turbulence and market volatility erode not just wealth, but, more importantly, health as well

Rachana Baid
CKG Nair

Investors in India, and elsewhere, are alarmed at the many global shock-waves that have hit them in recent times. The financial media is largely focused on wealth erosion: portfolio losses, FPI outflows, and currency depreciation. They are almost blind to the parallel casualty: erosion of physical and mental health among investors and savers.

Classical asset pricing theory holds that in frictionless financial markets, households should always allocate a fraction of their wealth to equities, since expected returns substantially exceed the risk-free rate. What the finance theories do not price in is the human body and its functioning.

Stock prices not only reflect investor psychology — they also determine it. Enough has been said about how investor behaviour influences market prices. Far less attention has been paid to the reverse: how market fluctuations shape investor psychology and physical health. There is empirical evidence that price movements directly influence instantaneous well-being — not gradually, not metaphorically, but measurably, on the same day.

Research published in reputed journals in the last two decades, spanning both finance and health, demonstrates that market volatility directly raises cardiovascular mortality, suicide rates, and psychiatric hospital admissions. A study, ‘Worrying About

the Stock Market: Evidence from Hospital Admissions’, published in the *Journal of Finance* (2013), examined patient records for hospitals in California over nearly three decades and found a direct link between market declines and hospital admissions — particularly for anxiety, panic attacks, and major depression.

When markets fell nearly 25 per cent, hospital admissions spiked by over 5 per cent immediately. The researchers’ conclusion was stark: stock market declines today result in psychological distress today.

A separate study from Fudan University (2024) demonstrated that a 1 per cent decrease in daily stock returns is associated with a 1.77 per cent increase in suicide mortality, concluding that stock market volatility is a significant public health issue.

UNIQUE DEMOGRAPHY
India’s unique demographic structure — a rapidly expanding retail investor base, a large proportion of first-generation investors with low income levels, many without any safety nets or behavioural guardrails, necessitates urgent attention to these issues. These are households for whom a 10-15 per cent portfolio drawdown is a real existential pain, not an abstraction. It is a visceral psychological emergency. Though no study on the health cost burden is available in the Indian context, it would be reasonable to assume substantial financial costs of medical care and income loss.

Financial wisdom tells us to take risk



HYPERTENSION. Will not disappear even after the market recovers (ISTOCKPHOTO)

— because a long life needs a bigger portfolio. But that same risk may shorten the life it was meant to fund.

The financial services industry has sophisticated tools for wealth protection: stop-losses, diversification, hedging, rebalancing. We have no equivalent vocabulary for health protection during financial stress. No brokerage firm sends a wellness alert alongside a margin call. No star cricketer reminds investors that their mental health matters as much as their SIPs. No market intermediary addresses the physiological dimension of investor protection.

The investment industry — its advisors, analysts, and media — has collectively treated investor wellbeing as a finance problem, measured in risk and returns, managed through asset allocation, and solved by staying invested. The health dimension has barely entered the room.

The evidence now demands a broader

leading to high level of NPAs. The unsavoury experience of the decade ending 2015, bears this out. A couple of years ago, the authors in an Op-ed had argued that credit growth rate should be close to nominal GDP growth rate. RBI Governor Malhotra in a recent interview echoed a similar view and dismissed suggestion of 2X credit growth as normal. The Governor further added that RBI does not specify any credit growth rate. But in our view, RBI may signal comfortable credit growth rate range along with projections of GDP and inflation numbers.

Allocative inefficiency: While the aggregate credit grew by only 206 per cent in the decade 2015-25, personal sector credit grew by a whopping 370 per cent. Infrastructure credit grew by 30 per cent and the large industry grew by a measly 28 per cent. The share of personal loans had significantly gone up from 20 per cent in 2015 to over 33 per cent and that of large corporates went down from 20 per cent to 15 per cent in 2025. Even in absolute terms personal loans are very high at ₹62 lakh crore, and with NBFC exposure of ₹16 lakh crore aggregating to ₹78 lakh crore. Loans to industry at ₹41 lakh crore are far lower (Table 2).

This model of debt induced consumption led growth is not sustainable for long. These are also subject to income shocks. Loan is no substitute for incomes and wages. There are already signs of stress in this sector. Flow of credit to productive and manufacturing purpose deserves more attention.

Housing loans which account for 50 per cent of personal segment need a reality check, though they are classified as secured. An IBA report indicates that over four lakh dwelling units are stressed and there are long delays in completion of these projects with potential credit losses. Many a banking crisis including 2008 Global Financial Crisis had its origins in excessive lending to this sector. Besides it may create asset price bubbles. Lenders need to revisit the mortgage models for large complexes.

(This is the first of a two-part article)

Rangarajan is former Chairman of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister and former Governor, Reserve Bank of India. Sambamurthy is formerly Director and CEO, IDBRT and led a commercial bank. Views are personal

definition of investor wellbeing. Investor education seminars, financial planning frameworks, and advisor training curriculum need to formally incorporate a component on overall health — physical, mental, and emotional. A longer, healthier life is not just a personal aspiration; it is a financial variable. How long you live, how well you live, and what your medical costs look like in your later years will shape your retirement corpus requirements just as directly as your asset allocation decisions.

Investors who maintain social support networks, limit their portfolio-checking, operate within pre-committed financial plans rather than reacting to daily movements, and hold genuinely diversified portfolios may show significantly lower stress biomarkers during market downturns.

The ongoing geopolitical situation will eventually resolve, as all crises do. Markets will recover.

Portfolios will be rebuilt. But the hypertension quietly developed over months of market anxiety, the sleep disorder that began the night arbitrary tariffs were announced — these do not disappear with market recovery. They will remain and worsen as the invisible ledger of our current times. In the relentless focus on what the market is doing to our wealth, let us not lose sight of what it is doing to our health, our lives.

Baid is Dean (Academics), National Institute of Securities Markets; Nair is its former Director. Views are personal

✉ LETTERS TO EDITOR Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Transit challenge

India joining Japan and China in developing a high-speed rail network for short-distance sectors could be a boon — significantly challenging the future relevance of the domestic aviation industry. Proposed routes such as Mumbai-Pune in 48 minutes, Bengaluru-Chennai in 78 minutes and Hyderabad-Bengaluru in just over two hours can transform the country’s travel landscape. High-speed rail will enjoy an added advantage as stations are usually located closer to city centres. Competitive fares with multiple travel classes could further lure

passengers away from airlines on these sectors. In the coming years, the contest between high-speed rail and aviation may redefine short-distance travel in India.

PV Prakash
Mumbai

Practising austerity

This refers to ‘Austere times’ (May 12). The Prime Minister wants us to adopt austerity measures. Almost 90 per cent of our gold demand is met through imports, almost akin to the situation on the oil front. So his concerns and suggestions are valid. But to build public trust

politicians must act like role models for the *aam aadmi* to follow. To save precious fuel, all of them must stop travelling in large convoys of vehicles and desist from organising huge rallies. Also, all chartered flights used by political leaders must be stopped.

Bal Govind
Noida

Misuse of Mythos

Claude Mythos, a system designed to probe vulnerabilities, risks becoming indistinguishable from the very threat it studies. Like a grandmaster in chess, true strength lies in

anticipating the opponent’s moves; yet, excessive preoccupation can tilt into mimicry of aggression itself. Mythos, in this sense, becomes more than a program to reflect the danger of systems that evolve by internalising adversarial logic. The question is not whether to think like the opponent, but how far one can go without becoming the very chaos one seeks to contain.

R Narayanan
Navi Mumbai

US-China diplomacy

This refers to ‘Trump’s China challenges’ (May 12). The piece

rightly captures the complexity of what awaits Trump in Beijing. What often gets lost in the noise around tariffs and Taiwan is how deeply economic interdependence shapes both sides’ choices. China holds \$760 billion in US Treasury bonds — that alone demands measured diplomacy, not brinkmanship. On Iran, Beijing’s calibrated distance from Tehran’s proxies suggests it prefers stability over solidarity. Both nations have more to lose from prolonged friction than from quiet accommodation.

M Barathi
Bengaluru

Making work redundant?

An NBER paper looks at AI and the future of work

Atanu Biswas

What makes the use of AI and robots different from previous technology is that only the most innovative, profoundly human work would survive. According to Elon Musk, the following 10-20 years might bring such revolutionary developments in AI that working itself would become optional.

AI and robots, such as Tesla's Optimus, would provide any goods and services you desire.

So, what would the future of human labour will look like? In his recent National Bureau of Economic Research working paper, entitled 'We Won't Be Missed: Work and Growth in the AGI World', Yale economist Pascual Restrepo — a distinguished expert on automation and labour markets — provided an alternative answer, considering the effects of AGI (Artificial General Intelligence) on production, growth, and labour markets in the long run. Restrepo outlined a world in which almost any job could be done by highly capable AI.

Restrepo distinguished between "bottleneck" and "supplementary" labour, taking for granted that AGI allows us to do all the useful work in the economy using "compute," the input that enables the technology to function.

"Bottleneck" work includes the jobs that are essential for the growth of the economy. According to Restrepo, bottleneck jobs sound very much like science fiction: "reducing existential risks, defending against asteroids, or mastering fusion energy." On the other hand, "supplementary" work consists of everything that the economy does not need to expand, such as customer service, hospitality, design, arts and crafts, and academic research.

Following Restrepo's model, the economy automates all bottleneck work by autonomous AI agents as more computing power becomes available, leaving a substantial portion of the labour market unaltered.

REVALUING SKILLS

In effect, Restrepo argues that "AGI does not render human skills obsolete; it revalues them." Some supplementary work may be left exclusively to humans. Human skills are priced by the opportunity cost of the compute required to replicate them, because compute is now the



AI. Major implications for labour

scarcity in the market rather than skill or intelligence.

Interestingly, the findings are contrary to both optimistic and pessimistic outlooks on the future of human work. In the age of AGI, it would be comforting to know that the majority of human work will not be automated. It's not because AGI cannot do that but because much of human work is simply not significant enough to warrant replacement.

Well, it's not likely to be positive for humans either. As Restrepo puts it, "the model opens up the intriguing possibility that much of today's work may not be essential for future growth and may never be automated."

One of the most disheartening conclusions that can be drawn about the report is the one stating that thriving thanks to growth and surviving automation are two entirely separate concepts.

WAGE-GDP DISCONNECT

Restrepo elaborates on how AGI would create a disconnect between wages and GDP. Probably the most shocking conclusion to be drawn from the study is the fact that labour's share in GDP would shrink towards zero.

Human labour is made economically insignificant — not useless, but very tiny compared to the entire economic pie — when human labour can only be reproduced at the fixed level of wage rates.

Per Restrepo, "The arrival of AGI cannot make us collectively worse off." Well, we won't be poorer, but we might not be richer either. And how long will it take us to see the validity of Restrepo's derivations? Ten to 20 years from now, or maybe 50 years or even more from now? And what happens if re-weighting supplementary labour changes the definition of GDP altogether? Who says that it may not give rise to an entirely new human-AGI economy dynamic?

The writer is Professor of Statistics, Indian Statistical Institute, Kolkata

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

May 13, 2006

Small car project: Tatas set to choose Bengal

The much-talked about small car project of Tata Motors is almost certain to be located in West Bengal. That is, if one is to go by what the Chief Minister of West Bengal, Mr Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee, had to say to reporters after the Managing Director of Tata Motors, Mr Ravi Kant, called on him at the State Government headquarters of Writers' Buildings here on Friday.

Govt tells cement cos to self-regulate prices

Worried over the "unacceptable and unjustified" increase in cement prices, the Government today told the cement manufacturers to give their suggestions by Monday regarding measures to reduce prices.

Reliance likely to invest \$6-7 b in KG basin

Reliance Industries Ltd on Fri day hinted at investing about \$ 6-7 billion (about Rs 27,000 crore to Rs 32,500 crore) to tap the huge natural gas potential in the Krishna-Godavari (KG) ba sin wells. By mid-2008, the first phase of the gas project in the KG ba sin will be ready. This project has the potential to add about \$20 billion to the GDP, and po tentially support 10,000 MW of power generation, according to Mr R.P. Sharma, President of Gas Business, Reliance Industries.

Google data centre's power challenges

If data centres exit the regular distribution utility, State utilities lose their most profitable customers

CAPITAL IDEAS.



RICHA MISHRA

When it comes to getting investments or branding, there are few politicians who can match Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu. No sooner had he come to power he had launched 'Power Sector Reforms 3.0' to address the State's energy crisis.

His current strategy focuses on aggressive cost reduction, a shift toward renewable energy, and institutional professionalisation.

To lure investors, Naidu and his team have been leaving no stone unturned. This was evident when Andhra Pradesh cleared a power distribution licence for a Google data centre in Visakhapatnam under a new policy.

The policy framework allows large data centres to manage their own power needs. This is in keeping with the Centre's thinking as well. The policy applies to projects with at least 300 MW load, enabling them to build and run their own power networks, according to information available.

A deemed licensee in Andhra Pradesh, under the Electricity Act, 2003, is an entity authorised to distribute electricity without a formal, separate licence, such as SEZ developers (based on 2010 notifications).

Before one looks into the challenges of this move, it is important to understand the key aspects of deemed licensees in Andhra Pradesh.

According to the Union Commerce Ministry's 2010 notification, SEZ developers are deemed distribution licensees. But, they are not automatically granted this status without meeting certain conditions or scrutiny, and sometimes require formal recognition by the Electricity Commission.

In Andhra Pradesh, the Andhra Pradesh Electricity Regulatory Commission (APERC) holds the authority to regulate, recognise, and oversee these deemed licensees to ensure compliance with the Electricity



POWER PLAY. DISCOMs fear losing profitable clients REUTERS

Act, 2003. The AP Electricity Duty Act includes the Andhra Pradesh State Electricity Board and authorised power corporations within the definitions of licensees. The licence allows power from multiple sources, including renewable energy, limited to their own use.

THE GUIDELINES

After obtaining the licensee status in Andhra Pradesh, the licence allows the holder to directly procure power — conventional and green — from various sources including open access and captive plants, to feed their data centres.

In this case, while Google will have distribution rights, it will operate under the regulation of the Andhra Pradesh Electricity Regulatory Commission and will not supply power to third-party consumers.

This is in a way entry of private sector into power distribution business, but with limited operations. Understandably, it will lessen pressure on the dedicated grids. But, the challenge may come in using the open access.

Google is no longer a standard high-tension consumer of the DISCOM, but the latter must maintain standby power to ensure 24x7 supply.

Open access has not really worked that well, as there are approval delays by existing distribution utilities (DISCOMs) because of fear of losing cream customers. Of course, ways have been worked around the policy, where grid access has been a challenge, battery storage has been used. Land acquisition is another challenge which deemed licensees could face.

But data centres are high-paying consumers and if they exit regular distribution utility, State utilities lose their most profitable customers.

DISCOMs use profits from High Tension (High Voltage) electricity supply/industrial users to subsidise agriculture and domestic tariff. The move would mean remaining consumers may face higher tariffs. Then there is an issue of stranded asset, which has led to debt for many distribution utilities. If big loads migrate, fixed costs get spread over fewer users.

Then comes the issue of transmission infrastructure. Data centres get to bypass the existing DISCOM but will use State transmission infrastructure. Of course, all these require APERC approval.

Critics say, if Google/Reliance get DISCOM licence, tomorrow steel, cement and ports may demand the same. The approval to Data Centre states that 51 per cent should be renewable. Data Centres need power round the clock, and

if renewable is unavailable, will they fall back on coal or grid?

LITIGATION WORRIES

The Supreme Court recently upheld that Indian Railways is not a deemed distribution licensee and remains liable to pay cross-subsidy and additional surcharge charges. In that context, Andhra Pradesh's decision to enable distribution rights for Google reflects how large consumers are increasingly seeking licensee status. This could trigger fresh litigation around cross-subsidy charges and further strain DISCOM revenues.

While it is advantage Google — 300 MW plus, smaller data centres/startups will be dependent on regular DISCOM tariff. Another critic said, if Google faces outage, only the government will be blamed.

Despite the media hype over significant autonomy conferred to Google as a Deemed Distribution Licensee (DDL), it does open the door to several complex technical, regulatory, and environmental challenges.

As a Deemed Distribution Licensee, Google is no longer a standard high-tension consumer of the local DISCOM, but the latter must still maintain rigorous standby power arrangements to ensure 24x7 supply.

To protect the State grid from sudden drops, Google must comply with strict Power Quality Regulations. Also the pricing structure for standby is significantly more expensive than Google's direct renewable PPAs.

APERC's guidelines for standby charges (which is charged when a data centre with a licence still wants to draw power from AP DISCOM as an emergency back-up) include premium pricing. Usually, no penalty is charged for exceeding the contracted maximum demand during an emergency standby period, provided prior notice is given to the DISCOM.

This is indeed a good move, but the power distribution market is yet to mature. The success of this move will set an example for future projects, so the onus is both on the State and Google, as any slip will not only impact the Data Centre but also affect regular consumers.

Short take

Leadership change: Starmer fights back

Alex Wickham
Alex Morales

Defiant Keir Starmer pushed back against widespread calls for him to quit as Britain's prime minister, telling his Cabinet that he wouldn't step down without a leadership fight.

In a high-stakes meeting with his most senior ministers on Tuesday, Starmer said efforts by members of Parliament to force him out in the wake of last week's disastrous local election results has been "destabilizing" and had had an economic cost for the country. The prime minister noted that no potential rival had announced a bid to challenge him.

"The country expects us to get on with governing," Starmer told ministers behind closed doors in 10 Downing St., according to a spokesperson. "That is what I am doing and what we must do as a Cabinet."

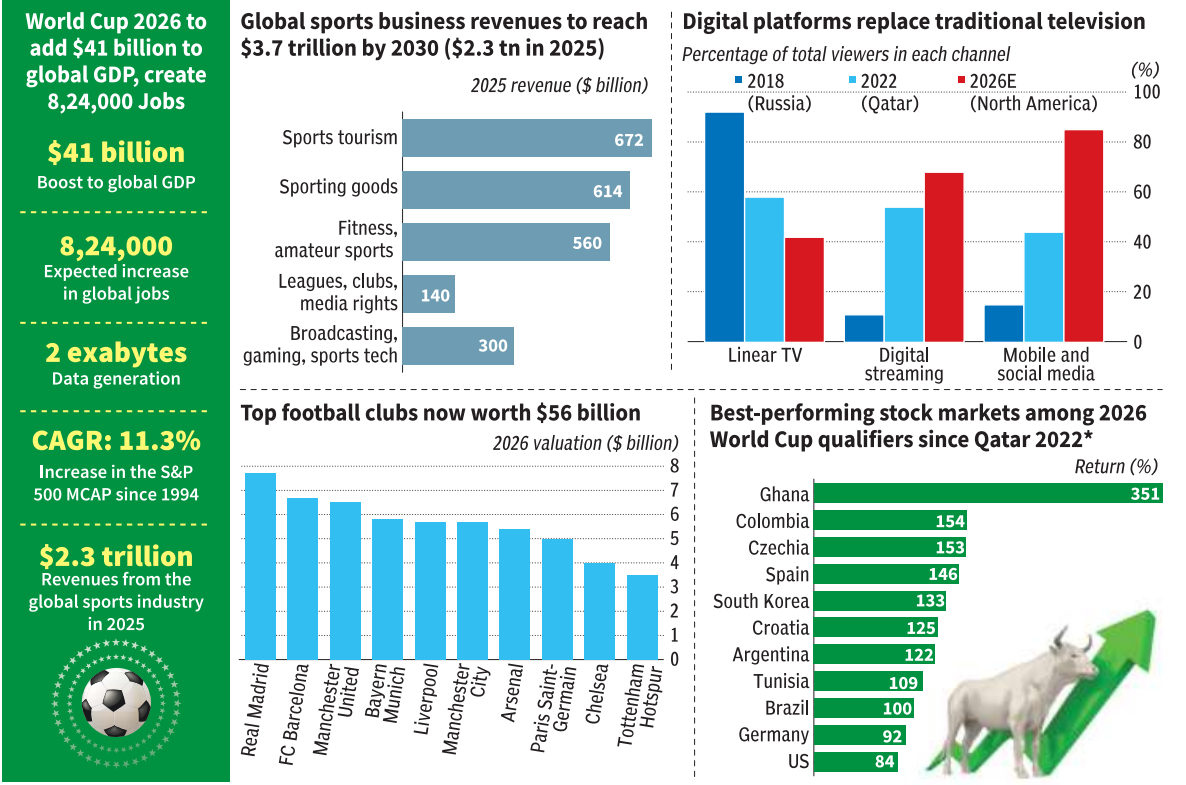
Starmer's remarks represented a last-ditch attempt to cling onto his job amid widespread speculation that he will be forced to announce a handover of power to a new leader as soon as Tuesday. He was supported by a handful of loyalists such as Housing Secretary Steve Reed. At least one minister seated around the Cabinet table, Health Secretary Wes Streeting, has been preparing for months to seek Starmer's job if the opportunity presented itself. BLOOMBERG

STATISTALK.

Compiled Dhurairvel Gunasekaran | Graphic Visweswaran V

How football World Cup 2026 moves global GDP, markets & capital

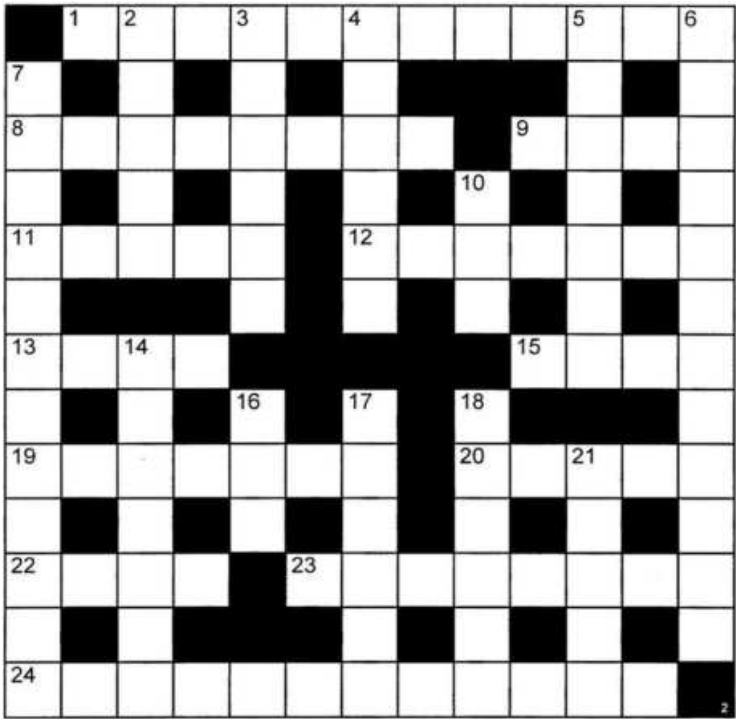
The 2026 FIFA World Cup is not just a sporting event but also a major economic and investment event, says Bank of America. It is projected to generate \$80 billion in economic output, add nearly \$41 billion to global GDP, and create over 8 lakh jobs worldwide. The global sports industry generated \$2.3 trillion in revenues in 2025 and could touch \$3.7 trillion by 2030, driven by tourism, sportswear, streaming, betting, broadcasting, and digital platforms. Digital platforms are rapidly replacing television, with the 2026 FIFA World Cup expected to drive higher streaming, mobile viewing and social media engagement globally. Key facts:



Source: The Beautiful Game: BofA's World Cup 2026 Guide

*Countries were ranked against their stock market performance (in US\$ terms)

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2678



EASY

ACROSS

- To and fro (4,3,5)
- With mind determined (8)
- A couple (4)
- Pass end of rope through (block) (5)
- Giddy, sick feeling (7)
- Profit (4)
- Assist(ance) (4)
- Line touching, not intersecting (7)
- Pleated frilling (5)
- Futile, unavailing (4)
- The cob (fruit) (5-3)
- Sabbath classes for the young (6,6)

DOWN

- Passageway, church division (5)
- Murderer (6)
- Born to a country (6)
- Come to see (7)
- The cornucopia (4,2,6)
- Peculiar privileges (12)
- Seaweed; mineral aggregate (3)
- Board showing name of hostelry (3-4)
- Narrow spouting stream (3)
- Drinking-tubes (6)
- Back part of gun (6)
- River in Africa (5)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- Like a shuttle, a footballer may hand fort over (4,3,5)
- Rose awkwardly with old instrument but with mind made up (8)
- Expected number of strokes to include one couple (4)
- To relieve fifty-one fewer, pass end of rope through (5)
- After five, disorder of goitre will produce giddy feeling (7)
- Put on weight for profit (4)
- Endless plea returned after hospital's call for assistance (4)
- A touching line has half the angles in embroidery stitch (7)
- Both ends of cloth in street in Paris used in dressmaking (5)
- Being proud of self is futile (4)
- Cob may laze around with the hunt (5-3)
- No sabbath vacation for such classes! (6,6)

DOWN

- Is steeped in beer as it runs between the seats (5)
- One to put an end to one sort of whale (6)
- One born in the country at four in the Northeast (6)
- One will, as it dawns on one, turn assets into cash (7)
- Often only half-phrase may be needed for cornucopia (4,2,6)
- Vote, sir, with grape responsible for such peculiar rights (12)
- From which to extract metal coin used in Scandinavia (3)
- It may show innings is thrown at the Lord's Tavern (3-4)
- Propulsive force just evades terrorist leaders (3)
- Tubes that create strife in the streets are given up (6)
- Part of the gun that looks right in wood (6)
- Bacon got bat away from Africa (5)

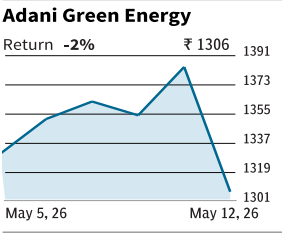
SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2677

ACROSS 1. Cherub 8. Ambit 9. Censure 11. Demented 12. Usury 15. Dive 16. May 17. Pail 19. Dummy 21. Muleteer 24. Tantrum. 25. Lupin 26. Turret

DOWN 2. Heels 3. Rosaries 4. Bird 5. Haven 6. Obit 7. Stud 10. Eel-basket 12. Undo 13. Splutter 14. Play 18. Stone 20. Mouse 21. Milk 22. Lips 23. Ran

QUICKLY.

Adani group stocks end lower in weak market



New Delhi: Adani group stocks ended lower on Tuesday, with Adani Green and Adani Power declining nearly 6 per cent, in-line with a bearish trend in equities. Shares of Adani Green Energy slumped 5.87 per cent, Adani Power fell by 5.63 per cent, NDTV edged lower by 4.78 per cent, Adani Total Gas was down 4.77 per cent, Adani Ports tanked 4.39 per cent, Adani Energy Solutions declined 4.14 per cent, Adani Enterprises Ltd dropped 3.82 per cent, Ambuja Cements skidded 2.24 per cent and ACC dipped 0.76 per cent on the BSE. The combined market valuation of these firms stood at ₹16.70 lakh crore. m

₹50 lakh penalty slapped on Kishore Biyani, others

New Delhi: SEBI on Tuesday imposed a total penalty of ₹50 lakh on three former officials of Future Retail Ltd (FRL), including Kishore Biyani for failing to comply with disclosure rules. Apart from Kishore Biyani, who was chairman and managing director, other top executives of the company penalised by SEBI are former MD Rakesh Biyani and the ex-Chief Financial Officer CP Toshniwal, according to an order passed by the SEBI. Biyanis were levied a fine of ₹20 lakh each, while a ₹10 lakh penalty was imposed on Toshniwal. The case pertains to violations of omitting the disclosure of certain related parties and RPTs in the annual report, or failing to seek approval from the audit committee or shareholders, as applicable. m

SEBI proposes phased physical settlement in select agri derivatives

OPEN INTEREST. Would allow exchanges to revive illiquid contracts or launch new delivery-based contracts

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India on Tuesday proposed allowing select agricultural commodity derivatives contracts to be financially-settled before consequent transition to compulsory physical settlement in a bid to boost liquidity.

The proposal would allow exchanges to revive illiquid contracts or launch new delivery-based contracts in select agricultural commodities that would initially trade as financially settled contracts.

These contracts would mandatorily transition to physical settlement once they cross pre-defined



GROUND WORK. On a pilot basis, the regulator said a few commodities such as maize, groundnut and chilli could be considered under the proposed framework. m

thresholds related to Average Daily Traded Volume (ADTV) and/or open interest, or after two years from launch, whichever is earlier.

“In the case of newly in-

troduced or thinly traded agricultural contracts, compulsory physical settlement from inception may unintentionally restrict participation to a narrow set of market participants who are

operationally capable of taking or giving delivery,” the regulator said in a draft paper, inviting public comments by June 2.

On a pilot basis, the regulator said a few commodities such as maize, groundnut and chilli could be considered under the proposed framework.

PHASED APPROACH

A phased approach is considered particularly relevant for agricultural commodities that have historically faced issues such as contract discontinuation and low trading volumes.

A temporary financially settled phase would enable market participants to build familiarity with contract specifications and price behaviour, while also allowing

exchanges time to strengthen warehousing, as-saying and delivery infrastructure, the regulator said.

PHYSICAL SETTLEMENT

The proposal has retained compulsory physical settlement with the eventual outcome, with contracts required to transition once sufficient market depth is achieved. Contract specifications relating to quality standards, delivery centres, and settlement mechanisms would be defined upfront.

The regulator said the proposal seeks to strike a balance between market development and the long-standing regulatory principle that agricultural commodity derivatives should ultimately be settled through physical delivery.

JSW Energy slumps 7% as brokerages turn cautious

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Shares of JSW Energy slumped 8 per cent to ₹512 in early trade on Tuesday despite the company reporting strong March quarter earnings growth, as investors reacted to higher valuations and cautious brokerage commentary following the recent rally in the stock.

The stock closed at ₹517.95, down 6.95 per cent on the NSE against the previous close of ₹556.65.

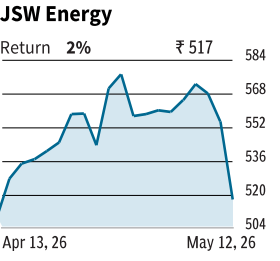
The company reported a 38 per cent y-o-y rise in consolidated net profit to ₹574 crore in Q4FY26 compared with ₹415 crore a year ago. Revenue from operations climbed 39 per cent y-o-y to ₹4,851 crore, while EBITDA jumped 72 per cent y-o-y to ₹2,602 crore, aided by contributions from Mahanadi, O2 Power and organic capacity additions. The board also recommended a dividend of ₹2 a share.

GROWTH VISIBILITY

Management said its scale-up strategy remains on track, with storage emerging as a key growth pillar and execution visibility staying strong. Installed capacity increased by 118 MW during the quarter. The company reiterated confidence in achieving its 30 GW target by 2030, with 13.4 GW operational, 14 GW under construction and a 4.6 GW pipeline.

JM Financial Downgraded the stock to Add from Buy with a revised target price of ₹627, citing expensive valuations after the recent run-up. The brokerage said adjusted r

evenue rose 38 per cent y-o-y to ₹4,400 crore, while adjusted profit after tax declined 36 per cent y-o-y to ₹260 crore. It noted elevated debt levels due to acquisitions and capex-heavy expan-



sion, though leverage metrics are expected to improve gradually.

Elara Capital also revised its rating to Accumulate from Buy and raised the target price to ₹602 from ₹581. The brokerage said JSW Energy is well positioned for long-term growth backed by a robust capacity addition pipeline, storage expansion plans and strong internal cash generation, but moderated its stance after a 14 per cent gain in the stock over the past three months. Axis Direct said strategy 3.0 targets a generation capacity of 30 GW and storage capacity of 40 GWh by 2030. Currently, it already has 29.6 GWh of locked-in energy storage capacity, which includes 26.4 GWh of PSP and 3.2 GWh of BESS. “We slightly raise our revenue and EBITDA estimates as we rationalise full-year contribution from assets commissioned in FY26 and a gradual improvement in operating leverage,” it said while retaining the target price at ₹630 with a buy call.

Motilal Oswal retained its Buy call with a target price of ₹640, valuing the business on a sum-of-the-parts basis. The brokerage said thermal assets were valued at 9x December 2027 estimated EBITDA, renewable energy at 12x FY28 estimated EBITDA and hydro assets at 2x December 2027 estimated book value. It added that the company's stake in JSW Steel was valued at a 25 per cent discount to the current market price.

SAT upholds SEBI order, says tax paid on unlawful gains cannot offset disgorgement

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT) has held that income tax paid on alleged unlawful gains cannot be deducted from disgorgement ordered by the Securities and Exchange Board of India, while partly allowing a review application filed by Alpesh Furiya and related entities.

The application sought reconsideration of SAT's January 29, 2026, order in a case involving alleged fraudulent trades linked to stock recommendations aired on television by Pradeep Pandya.

The appellants challenged

the earlier order on three grounds — the computation of disgorgement, denial of adjustment for the income tax paid on trading gains, and the imposition of ₹25 lakh as costs.

NO TAX RELIEF

Rejecting the plea on tax adjustment, SAT said any relief relating to income tax paid on the disputed gains would have to be pursued separately under tax laws.

“In our view, it is appropriate for the applicants to seek remedy under the Income Tax Act, 1961,” the Tribunal said. SAT said that the investigation period covered November 2019 to October



2021, while SEBI's disgorgement order was passed in June 2024.

“Referring to the ruling in Monal Y Thakker vs ACIT by the Income Tax Appellate Tribunal (ITAT), Ahmedabad, the Tribunal observed that payments made to SEBI in disgorgement proceedings had been excluded for income tax purposes in

that case. Appellants said that trades amounting to ₹3.16 crore had been executed before the stock recommendations were issued and therefore, should not have been included while calculating unlawful gains.

“The applicants' contention that the disgorgement must be calculated as the difference between quoted price at the time of recommendation and the sale price is meritless... the entire gain has been rightly construed by the WTM as wrongful gain and upheld by us in the order under review,” SAT said in an order. However, it granted partial relief by waiving the ₹25 lakh imposed earlier.

Analysts see headroom for Indian Hotels post strong Q4

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

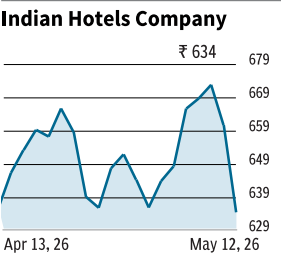
Shares of Indian Hotels Company failed to hold early gains on Tuesday and ended sharply lower amid weak broader market sentiment.

After reporting a strong March quarter performance, supported by healthy domestic demand and sustained momentum in its hospitality business, the stock rose 2 per cent in early trade to a high of ₹674.90 on the NSE. However, it later slipped to a day's low of ₹633.15 before closing near that level at ₹634.40, down 4.07 per cent from the previous close of ₹661.30.

The company posted a 15 per cent year-on-year rise in consolidated net profit to ₹600 crore in Q4FY26, compared with ₹522 crore in the year-ago quarter.

Revenue increased 14 per cent y-o-y to ₹2,845 crore, though the company said the West Asia conflict affected business momentum in March.

Brokerages remained con-



structive on the company's long-term outlook, driven by strong demand trends, expansion plans, and growth in new business segments.

GROWTH OUTLOOK

Motilal Oswal reiterated its Buy call with a sum-of-the-parts target price of ₹785. The brokerage said the company's growth outlook remains positive despite near-term geopolitical and macroeconomic uncertainties, aided by strong traction in the core business, strategic acquisitions, and expansion across niche hotel categories. It expects momentum to continue on the back of a robust room addition pipeline, favourable demand-supply dy-

namics, and rising MICE activity in India.

Elara Capital revised its rating to Accumulate from Buy and cut the target price to ₹716 from ₹858. The brokerage said subdued profitability in the owned hotel portfolio — which contributes nearly 80 per cent of revenue and 77 per cent of EBITDA — remains a drag. It also cited slower operationalisation of new large hotel openings and factored in the impact of the West Asia conflict and the realignment of hotel launches into its revised earnings estimates.

Axis Direct said IHCL continues to deliver industry-leading profitability, supported by strong pricing power, operating leverage, and disciplined asset management, while retaining.

Buy rating with a revised price target of ₹765 (₹820).

ICICI Securities, which retains a Buy with an STP-based revised TP of ₹916 (₹932), said fall in occupancy and slowdown in discretionary consumption are key risks.

Brookfield REIT's net operating income jumps 53%

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Brookfield India Real Estate Trust reported its highest-ever quarterly performance in Q4 FY26, driven by robust leasing activity and strong financial growth. The REIT reported gross leasing of 1.6 million sqft in the quarter, with nearly half contributed by global capability centres, the demand coming across tenant segments.

The REIT's net operating income surged 53 per cent y-o-y to ₹743 crore, while operating lease rentals rose 55.7 per cent to ₹712.3 crore. It declared a quarterly distribution of ₹5.50 per unit.

“FY26 marked a strong year, supported by record gross leasing of 4 million sq ft that led to occupancy growing by 5 per cent y-o-y,” said Alok Agarwal, MD and CEO, Brookfield India REIT.

3 US investors divest 4.7% stake in Groww for ₹5,326 crore

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

US-based Peak XV Partners, Ribbit Capital, and Y Combinator divested a combined 4.71 per cent stake in Billionbrains Garage Ventures, the parent company of Groww, on Tuesday for ₹5,326 crore through open market transactions.

A total of 29.52 crore shares representing a 4.71 per cent equity stake in Groww by the three investors, per the bulk deal data available on the NSE.

Start-up accelerator Y Combinator, through its arm YC Holdings II LLC, sold over 9.10 crore shares, or 1.45 per cent stake and Peak XV Partners, through its affiliate Peak XV Partners Investments VI-1, disposed of 6.20 crore shares in Bengaluru-based Groww. In

addition, venture capital firm Ribbit Capital, through its two arms — Ribbit Capital V LP and Ribbit — off-loaded over 14.21 crore shares in the stock broking firm, as per the data on the NSE.

The shares were sold in the range of ₹180.01-181.34, taking the combined transaction value to ₹5,325.77 crore.

At the end of the March quarter, Y Combinator through its arms — YC Holdings II, LLC and YCCG21 LP — owned a 11.25 per cent stake in Groww, while Peak XV Partners held 16.88 per cent and Ribbit Capital V 12.36 per cent.

Details of the buyers of could not be ascertained on the exchange.

Shares of Billionbrains Garage Ventures declined 4.98 per cent to close at ₹183.89 on the NSE.

BROKER'S CALL.

HSBC

PHYSICSWALLAH (BUY)

Target: ₹135
CMP: ₹107.25

Physicswallah (PW), which started as a YouTube channel in 2016, is now one of India's leading education technology companies offering both online and offline courses. Growth is underpinned by strong demand for quality education and the desire to succeed in highly competitive entrance examinations. The company is largely insulated from AI-driven disruption in India and relatively resilient during broader macroeconomic slowdowns. While favourable demographics — the average age in India is 28 — provide a structural tailwind, the employment backdrop is challenging. With job creation modest, academic credentials have become increasingly important to compete for limited opportunities, supporting growth in household spending on exam preparation. The industry is highly fragmented, led by hyper-local institutes and “star” teachers with only a few national players, so execution is key. PW's online model is affordable and scalable across the country.

We use a target EV/EBITDA multiple of 35x on our FY28e adjusted EBITDA of ₹960 crore to value PW. Including existing cash & equivalents of ₹5,000 crore, we value the equity at ₹38,600 crore or ₹135 a share. We initiate coverage of the stock at Buy. Over FY26-28e, we expect a nearly sevenfold increase in adjusted EBITDA to ₹960 crore. This will be led by a 30 per cent CAGR in revenues and a sharp jump in margins — from 3.6 per cent in FY26e to 15 per cent by FY28. Key downside risks include regulation changes, teacher attrition and increasing offline competition.

Elara Securities

AFFLE 3I (BUY)

Target: ₹2,240
CMP: ₹1,584.40

Affle 3i's Q4 performance was better than our estimates, with 20.3 per cent y-o-y revenue growth, led by India and emerging markets, up to 21.2 per cent. Growth was supported by deeper customer engagements, new logo additions, and continued traction across key industry verticals and geographies. Developed markets grew 18 per cent y-o-y as deferred revenue kicked in. Gross margin declined 114 bps to 38 per cent, due to discretionary investment in expansion. EBITDA margin rose 120bps y-o-y to 22.5 per cent in FY26 on lower cost, bringing AFFLE closer to its 23-24 per cent margin guidance. The company is entering a strategic phase of scaling its revenue base for the AI-led advertising ecosystem, with management's inorganic push into developed markets appearing structurally positive.

Affle is set to achieve about 20 per cent near-term revenue growth. The stock has been down by about 14 per cent in the past six months. We expect EBITDA margin to remain broadly stable in the 23-24 per cent band, supporting healthy earnings visibility. We maintain Buy with target price unchanged at ₹2,240. Our estimates during FY27-28E for revenue remain unchanged while EPS estimates are down by 10 per cent on the back of high other income base in FY26. Near-term risks include execution, integration and potential margin dilution if acquired entities carry structurally weaker profitability, similar to earlier acquisition cycles.

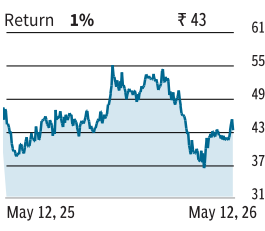
businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY'S PICK.

Sagility (₹43.09): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Sagility



Sagility at ₹43 and accumulate at ₹41.50. Place stop-loss at ₹39. When the stock rises to ₹48, revise the stop-loss to ₹44. On a rally to ₹51, tighten the stop-loss to ₹48. Book profits at ₹53.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

The stock of Sagility broke out of a key resistance at ₹43 last week. This led to it forming a higher high and the breakout also confirmed a cup and handle chart pattern, indicating a bullish reversal in trend.

Even though the stock dropped 4.2 per cent on Monday, it is likely to be a retest of the resistance-turned-support level of ₹43. While the downturn might extend to ₹41.50, we expect the stock to eventually resume the rally. In the coming weeks, it can hit ₹53.

Therefore, traders can buy

Day trading guide

23470 » Nifty 50 Futures					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
23400	23100	23600	23800	Sell the contract if it falls below 23400; stop-loss can be 23600.	

₹751 » HDFC Bank					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
748	740	760	770	Go short when the stock rises to 760; place stop-loss at 775.	

₹1140 » Infosys					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1120	1100	1150	1165	Short the stock now and at 1150; stop-loss can be at 1170.	

₹301 » ITC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
300	295	305	308	Sell the stock if it declines below 300; stop-loss can be at 305.	

₹295 » ONGC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
290	285	300	308	Go long on the stock if the price dips to 290; stop-loss at 280.	

₹1363 » Reliance Ind.					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1340	1310	1390	1405	Go short on the stock if it rises to 1390; place stop-loss at 1415.	

₹974 » SBI					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
960	945	985	1000	Likely to see a corrective rise; go long with a stop-loss at 950.	

₹2300 » TCS					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
2280	2250	2340	2360	Short the stock now and at 2340; stop-loss can be at 2370.	

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers

	Close(t)	Pts	PE	WN(t)
ONGC	294.50	11.43	8.24	1.07
Hindalco	1041.40	5.65	14.56	1.41
State Bank	974.60	0.90	10.38	3.77
Tata Steel	212.00	-0.14	29.01	1.63
NTPC	392.70	-0.26	15.34	1.74
Coal India	463.05	-0.69	9.18	0.98
Dr Reddys Lab	1270.00	-1.32	19.19	0.72
Apollo Hosp	8022.50	-1.33	61.82	0.77
Cipla	1292.30	-1.55	23.03	0.68
Bharti Airtel	1756.80	-2.01	28.60	5.03
NestleIndia	1468.60	-2.08	80.93	0.98
JSW Steel	1252.30	-2.11	39.43	1.10
Eicher Motors	7126.00	-2.30	36.49	0.91
TataConsumerProduct	1253.00	-2.56	80.16	0.76
Max Healthcare	1017.70	-3.29	69.78	0.71
Tata Motors PV	336.85	-4.18	45.81	0.66
Wipro	189.57	-4.43	14.99	0.51
PowerGrid Corp	306.30	-4.54	18.35	1.29
Bajaj Auto	10397.00	-4.80	27.48	1.07
IntGlobalEavi	4201.70	-4.82	50.59	0.89
HDFC Life	601.80	-4.90	67.90	0.60
SBI Life	1833.90	-4.95	74.46	0.77
Adani Enter	2405.20	-5.94	31.23	0.64
Asian Paints	2505.50	-5.97	61.46	1.06
Bajaj Finserv	1744.80	-6.22	14.20	0.94
Sun Pharma	1845.70	-6.23	40.43	1.82
Trent Ltd.	4050.60	-6.31	83.65	0.84
Grasim Ind	2903.00	-7.04	20.86	1.03
JS Financial Services Ltd.	230.47	-7.65	93.81	0.70
Axis Bank	1260.10	-7.63	14.75	3.37
Kotak Bank	376.00	-8.11	19.39	2.58
Hind Unilever	2262.00	-8.75	50.22	1.87
Maruti Suzuki	13172.00	-8.90	28.21	0.61
Tech Mahindra	1392.90	-8.93	28.40	1.82
UltraTech Cement	11516.00	-9.04	41.44	1.27
Eternal Ltd.	239.98	-9.25	63.62	1.61
ITC	300.70	-10.82	18.20	2.70
HCL Tech	1145.80	-11.30	18.67	1.13
Bharat Elec	416.50	-12.07	51.06	1.39
Adani Ports	1688.20	-12.72	30.43	1.16
Titan	4055.30	-13.52	70.95	1.56
M&M	3314.00	-25.44	50.64	1.27
Shriram Finance Ltd.	930.45	-13.89	21.84	1.22
Bajaj Finance	904.20	-18.58	29.10	2.26
TCS	2300.30	-20.62	16.83	2.19
L&T	3856.50	-21.43	27.99	4.22</

Canara Bank sees more money flowing into deposits amid market volatility

STRONG MOMENTUM. Bank to sharpen focus on low-cost liabilities and high-yield retail lending

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Public sector lender Canara Bank is betting on a behavioural shift among Indian consumers, from spending and investing in volatile as-sets to parking more money in bank deposits, as it sharpens focus on low-cost liabilities and high-yield re-tail lending.

MD and CEO (In-charge) Hardeep Singh Ahluwalia said the bank expects savings deposits and retail term de-posits to see healthy traction in the coming quarters as consumers turn more cau-tious amid stock market volatility and changing spending patterns.

“With the change in con-



With the change in consumer behaviour, we will see more deposits coming into the banking channel.

HARDEEP SINGH AHLUWALIA
MD and CEO (In-charge)

sumer behaviour, we will see more deposits coming into the banking channel,” Ahluwalia told *businessline*, adding that the bank is already seeing strong mo-mentum in savings and retail deposits. The dip was largely because last year included a one-time gain of ₹1,930 crore from stake dilution in subsidiaries — Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company



Limited and Canara Robeco Asset Management Com-pany. Core banking paramet-ers remain strong,” Ahluwalia said.

TREASURY LOSSES

In addition, the quarter was also impacted by treasury-related mark-to-market losses amid adverse bond yield movements and equity market corrections. He said

the spike in the 10-year G-Sec yield and the fall in equity markets led to treas-ury losses during the quarter, though he expects the situ-ation to stabilise as yields soften.

The bank is simultan-ously recalibrating its liabil-ities strategy by reducing de-pendence on bulk deposits and improving the share of retail deposits to protect margins. According to Ahluwalia, the bank reduced its deposit costs by nearly ₹700 crore during the quarter through “cost blend-ing”, helping improve net in-terest margins by 9 bps dis-pite the easing rate cycle.

RETAIL PUSH

On the lending side, the bank continues to aggressively

push retail, agriculture and MSME (RAM) loans, which are growing at over 19 per cent and now account for 59 per cent of its overall loan mix. The bank sees the seg-ment as more attractive due to higher spreads and lower concentration risks com-pared to corporate lending.

Canara Bank is also seeing sustained traction in gold loans, particularly in south-ern markets, and expects de-mand to remain strong as lower rates support retail borrowing.

Going ahead, the lender plans to deepen its premium banking and digital lending push, including expanding relationship-led offerings for high-net-worth customers and scaling digital loan jour-neys across RAM segments.

Torrent Pharma expects to conclude JB Chemicals merger in 1-2 months

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Torrent Pharmaceuticals said the merger process of Mumbai-based JB Chemicals & Pharmaceuticals Ltd with the company has entered its final stage, with a hearing scheduled in the second week of June and the trans-action expected to become effective over the next one to two months.

“On the merger process we have received the requis-ite shareholder approval for merger of JB Pharma with Torrent and we are in the last stage of the process,” Aman Mehta, Managing Director of Ahmedabad-based Torrent Pharmaceuticals and a Board member of JB Chemicals said while addressing in-vestors. “We are in the last phase of the merger process and the hearing date which

we got is in the second week of June. The merger should get effective in one-two months,” he added.

The merger scheme had received shareholder ap-provals from both compan-ies in April this year, along with approvals from public shareholders and no-objec-tion letters from stock ex-changes.

EXCHANGE RATIO

Under the approved share exchange ratio, shareholders of J. Chemicals, excluding Torrent Pharmaceuticals, will receive 51 equity shares of Torrent Pharma for every 100 shares held in JB Chem-icals. The appointed date for the merger is January 21, 2026.

Torrent Pharma has already been exercising op-erational control over JB Chemicals for the last four months as part of the integ-

ration process. “The brands in the India business in par-ticular continue to give us confidence. These are such widely established and re-cognized brands and famili-arity is so high that in a merged entity it could cer-tainly be possible to grow further,” Mehta said.

The company indicated that the merged entity would increasingly focus on strengthening the India busi-ness, which it sees as the key long-term growth driver. “The objective that we have taken is to change the mix profile and growth profile of the company as JB which would be more geared to In-dia growth as an outperform-ance driver rather than a mix of international and India,” Mehta said.

Torrent Pharma also sig-nalled rationalisation within the field force as integration progresses.

MobiKwik posts profits for 2nd straight quarter

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Fintech firm MobiKwik re-ported its second consecut-ive profitable quarter in Q4 FY26, driven by strong growth in its payments and financial services businesses, even as the company contin-ued to invest in new growth verticals such as merchant acquiring and AI-led products.

The company posted a profit after tax of ₹4.4 crore in the March quarter, com-pared with a loss of ₹56 crore a year earlier. EBITDA for the quarter stood at ₹17.4 crore against a loss of ₹45.8 crore in the corresponding period last year, marking an im-provement of ₹63.2 crore year-on-year.

Revenue from operations rose 8 per cent year-on-year to ₹288.7 crore during the quarter, while contribution profit more than doubled to ₹135.1 crore. For the full fiscal year, the company nar-rowed its EBITDA loss sharply to ₹5.2 crore from ₹79.4 crore in FY25.

“We delivered a profitable H2 as committed, and achieved a Rs 74.2 crore EBITDA swing that demon-strates the strength of our model,” Bipin Preet Singh, Founder and CEO, said in a statement. “Scaling responsi-bly and building profitabili-ty are not at odds; they are firmly aligned.”

CORE BIZ GROWS

The Gurugram-based com-pany said its core payments and lending businesses gen-erated positive EBITDA of ₹49.5 crore in FY26. How-ever, it invested ₹54.7 crore during the year towards building its merchant pay-ments business, which it ex-

Q4 AT A GLANCE

- The company posted a PAT of ₹4.4 crore in the March quarter, compared with a loss of ₹56 crore a year earlier.
- EBITDA stood at ₹17.4 crore against a loss of ₹45.8 crore

pects to scale significantly over the next two years.

MobiKwik’s payments gross merchandise value (GMV) grew 58 per cent year-on-year to ₹52,400 crore in Q4, while full-year GMV rose 57 per cent to ₹1.82 lakh crore.

Its buy-now-pay-later of-fering ZIP EMI also contin-ued to see strong traction, with GMV growing 59 per cent year-on-year to ₹837.7 crore in Q4.

Financial services revenue rose 37 per cent year-on-year to ₹77.1 crore, while gross profit from the segment surged sharply on improved credit quality and collections.

FOCUS AREAS

The company said FY27 will see a sharper focus on scaling merchant acquiring, strengthening its non-bank-ing finance company opera-tions and embedding arti-ficial intelligence across products and operations.

“Over the next two years, we will scale up our core business while building four new growth engines: offline and online merchant acquir-ing, unlocking lending through our NBFC, and AI powering everything we do,” Singh said.

With inputs from BL intern Vasundhara Prakash

RBI cancels licence of Sarvodaya Co-op Bank

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank on Tues-day cancelled the licence of city-based Sarvodaya Co-op-erative Bank due to a lack of adequate capital and earning prospects.

Consequently, the bank ceases to carry on banking business, with effect from the close of business on May 12, 2026, it said in a statement.

The RBI has asked the Commissioner for Coopera-tion and Registrar of Co-operative Societies, Maha-rashtra, to issue an order for the winding up of the bank and to appoint a liquidator. On liquidation, every de-positor would be entitled to receive the deposit insur-ance claim amount of his/her deposits up to ₹5 lakh from the Deposit Insurance and Credit Guarantee Corpora-tion (DICGC).

“As per the data submitted by the bank, about 98.36 per cent of the depositors were entitled to receive the full amount of their deposits from DICGC as on the date of imposition of All Inclusive Directions,” the central bank said.

As on March 31, 2026, DICGC has already paid ₹26.72 crore of the total in-sured deposits.

Giving reasons for the li-cence cancellation, the RBI said the co-op bank, with its present financial position, would be unable to pay its current depositors in full.

“Public interest would be adversely affected if the bank is allowed to carry on its banking business any fur-ther,” RBI said.



Paradeep Phosphates Limited

PARADEEP PHOSPHATES LIMITED

Regd. Office: 5th Floor, Bayan Bhawan, Pt J N Marg, Bhubaneswar - 751 001
Tel: +91 080 46812500; E-mail: cs.ppl@adventz.com; Website: www.paradeepphosphates.com
CIN - L20122OR1981PLC001020

Extract of Statement of Audited Financial Results for the Quarter and Year ended March 31, 2026

Sr. No.		STANDALONE					CONSOLIDATED				
		3 Months ended 31-03-2026	3 Months ended 31-12-2025	3 Months ended 31-03-2025	Year ended 31-03-2026	Year ended 31-03-2025	3 Months ended 31-03-2026	3 Months ended 31-12-2025	3 Months ended 31-03-2025	Year ended 31-03-2026	Year ended 31-03-2025
		(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)
		(Rs. in Crore)	(Rs. in Crore)	(Rs. in Crore)	(Rs. in Crore)	(Rs. in Crore)	(Rs. in Crore)	(Rs. in Crore)	(Rs. in Crore)	(Rs. in Crore)	(Rs. in Crore)
1	Total income from operations	4,741.81	5,779.65	4,253.80	21,972.92	17,106.69	4,741.81	5,779.65	4,253.80	21,972.92	17,106.69
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before Tax	200.30	274.68	238.50	1,367.87	911.59	200.30	274.68	238.50	1,367.38	910.87
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Items)	202.18	233.37	238.50	1,328.45	911.59	202.18	233.38	238.50	1,327.96	910.87
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional Items)	155.60	182.05	172.19	996.84	662.85	155.60	182.06	172.19	996.35	662.13
5	Total Comprehensive Income / (Loss) for the period [comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income / (Loss) (after tax)]	160.88	181.26	169.09	1,000.45	657.53	161.07	181.30	169.09	1,000.81	657.62
6	Paid up Equity Share Capital (Face Value of Rs. 10/- each)				1,038.17	815.21				1,038.17	815.21
7	Other Equity				5,744.49	5,060.12				5,744.52	5,059.80
8	Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 10/- each) (not annualised)										
	(a) Basic (Rs)	1.50	1.76	1.66	9.61	6.39	1.50	1.75	1.66	9.60	6.39
	(b) Diluted (Rs)	1.50	1.75	1.66	9.60	6.39	1.50	1.75	1.66	9.59	6.38

NOTES:

- The above is an extract of the detailed format of the financial results for the quarter and period ended 31st March 2026, filed with the Stock Exchanges on 11th May 2026 under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Audited Financial Results for the quarter and year ended 31st March 2026 are available on the Company's website www.paradeepphosphates.com and on the website of the Stock Exchanges www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com and can be accessed by scanning the QR code below.
- The results have been prepared in accordance with the Indian Accounting Standards ("Ind AS") as prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with relevant rules issued thereunder.



For and on behalf of the Board of Directors of
Paradeep Phosphates Limited
Sd/-
N Suresh Krishnan
Managing Director
DIN: 00021965

Place : Bengaluru
Date : May 11, 2026

SUPPLYCO

THE KERALA STATE CIVIL SUPPLIES CORPORATION LTD.
P.B. No. 2030, Maveli Bhavan, Gandhi Nagar,
Kochi - 682020, PH: 0484-2207923 Mob: 828123098
E-mail: supplycopaddyho@gmail.com

E-TENDER FOR GUNNY (JUTE) BAGS
Supplyco invites competitive bids for the supply of new B -Twill gunny (jute) bags through e-tender. Only suppliers possessing digital signatures will be permitted to participate in the E-tender.

LAST DATE FOR SUBMISSION
21-05-2026 12.00 PM
For tender forms and further details please visit <https://www.etenders.kerala.gov.in>



K.P.R. MILL LIMITED

CIN : L17111TZ2003PLC010518

Registered Office : No.9 Gokul Building, 1 Floor, A.K.S.Nagar, Thadagam Road, Coimbatore - 641 001.
Email : corporate@kprmill.com Web : www.kprmilllimited.com Phone : 0422-2207777

STATEMENT OF AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS (CONSOLIDATED) FOR THE QUARTER / YEAR ENDED 2026 (₹ in Lakhs)

Sl.No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended			Year Ended	
		31.03.2026 (Audited)*	31.12.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2025 (Audited)*	31.03.2026 (Audited)	31.03.2025 (Audited)
1	Total Income from operations	1,82,516	1,50,092	1,78,015	6,78,429	6,46,226
2	Net Profit for the period (before tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	31,980	26,300	28,073	1,13,400	1,06,278
3	Net Profit for the period before tax, (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	31,980	26,300	28,073	1,13,400	1,06,278
4	Net Profit for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	22,717	20,860	20,455	86,650	81,511
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit for the period (after tax) and other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	22,717	20,860	20,455	86,650	81,511
6	Equity Share Capital (Face Value of ₹ 1 each)	3,418	3,418	3,418	3,418	3,418
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance sheet of the previous year.				5,66,342	4,96,782
8	Earnings Per Share (of ₹ 1/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) Basic and Diluted Earnings per share (in ₹) (Not annualised for quarters)	6.65	6.10	5.98	25.35	23.85

Note :

1) Standalone Results

(₹ in Lakhs)					
1	(a) Revenue from operations	1,16,640	1,04,918	1,11,805	4,30,637
	(b) Other income	8,111	2,919	5,739	19,779
	Total Income from operations	1,24,751	1,07,837	1,17,544	4,50,416
2	Profit before tax	21,318	18,534	20,687	78,286
3	Total comprehensive income (After tax)	16,955	14,227	15,191	60,602

2) The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Results filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites.BSE:<http://www.bseindia.com>, NSE:<http://www.nseindia.com>, Company's website: <https://www.kprmilllimited.com/financial-result-audited-unaudited>. This can also be accessed by scanning a Quick Response Code given below:

3) The above financial results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee on 12.05.2026 and taken on record and approved by the Board of Directors at their meeting held on 12.05.2026. The above results have been subjected to audit by the statutory auditors of the Company. The report of statutory auditors is unqualified.

4) The Government of India, with Effect from November 21, 2025, notified the code on social security, 2020, the Occupational Safety, Health and working Conditions Code, 2020, the Industrial relations Code, 2020 and the Code on Wages, 2019 (collectively, the "Labour Codes"), which replace existing central labour legislations. Based on the Company's assessment, the provisions currently in force do not have a material impact on the financial results of the Company.

5) * The figures for the quarters ended March 31, 2026 and March 31, 2025 are the balancing figures between the audited figures in respect of the full financial years and the published unaudited year-to-date figures upto the third quarter of the respective financial years, which were subjected to limited review.

6) Events after reporting period :

The Board has recommended a Final Dividend of 250 % (₹ 2.50 per share of the face value of ₹ 1/- each) for the year 2025-26 subject to the approval of the Shareholders in Annual General Meeting.



For K.P.R.MILL LIMITED
P.Nataraj
Managing Director
DIN : 00229137

Coimbatore
12.05.2026



V-GUARD INDUSTRIES LTD.
Registered Office: 42/962, Vennala High School Road, Vennala, Ernakulam-682 028, Kerala.
Tel : 0484-4335000, Email : mail@vguard.in CIN: L31200KL1996PLC010010



Extract of Audited Standalone Financial Results for the Quarter and Year ended 31.03.2026 (₹ in crores)

Sl. No	Particulars	For the three months ended			For the year ended	
		31.03.2026	31.12.2025	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025
		(Refer note 3 below)	(Unaudited)	(Refer note 3 below)	(Audited)	(Audited)
1.	Total income from operations (net)	1,687.16	1,325.92	1,480.07	5,691.78	5,308.87
2.	Net Profit / (Loss) from ordinary activities after tax	95.35	42.34	78.06	259.37	260.22
3.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period / year after tax (after extraordinary items)	95.35	42.34	78.06	259.37	260.22
4.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period / year [comprising profit / (loss) for the period / year (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income] after tax	94.68	42.34	75.07	258.70	257.23
5.	Equity Share Capital	43.68	43.63	43.58	43.68	43.58
6.	Earnings per share of ₹ 1/- each (before extraordinary items)					
	(a) Basic:	2.17	0.97	1.78	5.92	5.95
	(b) Diluted:	2.17	0.96	1.78	5.90	5.92
7.	Earnings per share of ₹ 1/- each (after extraordinary items)					
	(a) Basic:	2.17	0.97	1.78	5.92	5.95
	(b) Diluted:	2.17	0.96	1.78	5.90	5.92

Extract of Audited Consolidated Financial Results for the Quarter and Year ended 31.03.2026 (₹ in Crores)

Sl. No	Particulars	For the three months ended			For the year ended	
		31.03.2026	31.12.2025	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025
		(Refer note 3 below)	(Unaudited)	(Refer note 3 below)	(Audited)	(Audited)
1.	Total income from operations (net)	1,755.27	1,403.51	1,538.08	5,965.78	5,577.82
2.	Net Profit / (Loss) from ordinary activities after tax	112.13	57.06	91.13	308.33	313.72
3.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period / year after tax (after extraordinary items)	112.13	57.06	91.13	308.33	313.72
4.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period / year [comprising profit / (loss) for the period / year (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income] after tax	111.38	57.06	87.99	307.58	310.58
5.	Equity Share Capital	43.68	43.63	43.58	43.68	43.58
6.	Earnings per share of ₹ 1/- each (before extraordinary items)					
	(a) Basic:	2.56	1.30	2.08	7.03	7.17
	(b) Diluted:	2.55	1.30	2.07	7.01	7.14
7.	Earnings per share of ₹ 1/- each (after extraordinary items)					
	(a) Basic:	2.55	1.30	2.08	7.03	7.17
	(b) Diluted:	2.55	1.30	2.07	7.01	7.14

QUICKLY.

CPPIB India to acquire stake in Ctrl S Datacenters



New Delhi: Fair trade regulator CCI on Tuesday cleared CPPIB India Private Holdings’ proposal to acquire a stake in Ctrl S Datacenters Ltd. CPPIB India Private Holdings is a wholly-owned subsidiary of CPPIB (Canada Pension Plan Investment Board). The Canadian pension fund manager invests in public equities, private equities, real estate, infrastructure and fixed-income instruments. “CCI approves acquisition by CPPIB India Private Holdings Inc of certain shareholding in Ctrl S Datacenters Ltd.”

JCD Prabhakar elected TN Assembly Speaker



Chennai: JCD Prabhakar (*in picture*), the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhaga (TVK) MLA from Thousand Lights constituency, was elected unopposed as Speaker of the 17th Tamil Nadu Assembly. Prabhakar was the only MLA to file the nomination to Assembly Secretary K Srinivasan on Monday. Prabhakaran had won two times from the Villivakkam constituency as a member of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam. He left the party just before the elections to join the TVK. M Ravishankar, MLA from Thuraiyur (SC) (Tiruchirappalli) constituency, was elected unopposed as the Deputy Speaker.

‘India has strong economic runway for 15-20 years’

GROWTH DRIVERS. Country offers macroeconomic resilience, political stability, demographic strength that are rare among emerging markets: Citi India chief

bl.interview

**K Ram Kumar
Janaki Krishnan**
Mumbai

While Citi exited the consumer banking business in India three years ago, its institutional business has grown substantially, with the franchise now larger than when it operated both retail and institutional businesses together. K Balasubramanian, India Subcontinent Sub-Cluster & Banking Head, and India CEO & Banking Head, Citi, said the bank remains highly bullish on India, and sees the country as one of the most compelling long-term growth stories globally. *Edited excerpts:*

How does Citi view the India growth opportunity?
We remain highly bullish on



We expect M&A activity in India to increase significantly over the next decade

K BALASUBRAMANIAN
India Subcontinent Sub-Cluster & Banking Head, and India CEO & Banking Head, Citi



India and see the country as one of the most compelling long-term growth stories globally. India offers a combination of macroeconomic resilience, political stability, demographic strength and policy continuity that is rare among emerging markets. Even after quitting the consumer banking business in India three years ago, our institutional business has grown substantially. Our franchise today is larger — both in terms of balance sheet and profitability

— than when we operated both retail and institutional businesses together. Our growth has been driven by a sharper focus on our core strengths, particularly institutional banking, capital markets, transaction banking and cross-border financing. We believe India has a strong economic runway for at least the next 15-20 years, supported by a young population, rising consumption and sustained infrastructure investment. With nearly 62-63 per cent of GDP driven by

consumption, the country is expected to remain one of the fastest-growing major economies globally. India has managed geopolitical and economic disruptions better than many emerging markets by diversifying energy sources and maintaining stable bilateral relationships.

How significant is India to Citi’s global business today?
India has emerged as one of the most important markets globally for Citigroup, both in terms of revenue contribution and strategic relevance. In the bank’s global revenues, which stand at a little over \$80 billion, India contributes more than \$2 billion. However, the comparison becomes even more significant once Citi’s global consumer banking business is excluded, since we quit the retail banking segment in India. On a like-to-like institu-

tional business basis, India now contributes roughly 4-5 per cent of Citi’s global revenues, making it one of the bank’s top five international franchises outside North America. **What are the key themes driving India’s long-term growth?**
We see multiple structural drivers supporting India’s transformation into a developed economy. The *Viksit Bharat* vision would require India’s per capita income to rise from under \$3,000 currently to over \$10,000 in the coming decades. Achieving this target would require massive investments across infrastructure, manufacturing, energy transition and social sectors. Infrastructure investment is expected to span roads, ports, airports, power, logistics and urban development. We also believe climate transition and renewable energy are no longer optional

for India but an economic necessity. India would require capital investments of \$8-10 trillion over the next two decades. Domestic savings alone will not be sufficient to meet this requirement, making foreign capital critical for India’s growth ambitions. We expect FDI, portfolio flows, sovereign wealth funds, private equity, development finance institutions and institutional investors to play a major role. We see ourselves as a key intermediary in channelling global capital into India and supporting both government and corporate financing requirements. **What opportunities do you see in mergers and acquisitions (M&A)?**
We expect M&A activity in India to increase significantly over the next decade. We have been a strong proponent of allowing Indian banks to participate more

actively in acquisition financing. Traditionally, the financing pool for such deals was largely limited to foreign banks. Indian banks now have stronger capital adequacy and greater lending capacity, which will help expand the acquisition financing market. We expect two broad trends to drive deal-making in India: rising demand for quality Indian assets from private equity investors and global capital; and succession-related transitions in family-owned businesses, where second or third-generation promoters may not want to continue operating businesses traditionally. So, these dynamics would create more consolidation opportunities across sectors. As a leading M&A and equity capital markets advisor, our strategy is to originate transactions and syndicate them across multiple Indian banks, rather than relying on exclusive partnerships.

Syrma SGS expects 30% revenue growth in FY27, exports to cross ₹1,500 cr: MD

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Electronics manufacturing services (EMS) player Syrma SGS expects a revenue growth of around 30 per cent in FY27. Exports revenue, which makes up 25 per cent of total revenue, is likely to touch about ₹1,500 crore, Jasbir Singh Gujral, Managing Director of Syrma SGS Technology, told *businessline*. However, given the macroeconomic situation-led cost pressures, the EMS company is guiding for a conservative EBITDA margin at 10.5-11 per cent, compared to the 12 per cent it delivered

in FY26. “It’s very tough to say [when the West Asia situation will be stable]. The present stalemate is not a solution. It will hurt everyone,” said Gujral. Manufacturing enterprises, by nature, are frugal and do not get carried away by profits, and we are controlling costs even before the recent advisory by the PM, he added. **WEST ASIA CRISIS**
Gujral highlighted the impact of the West Asia crisis on logistics, freight and insurance costs, along with rising prices for inputs such as copper and polymers. However, the company did not face any direct impact from memory chips or indus-

trial gases. FY26 was a strong year of execution for Syrma SGS, with 27 per cent revenue growth at ₹4,819 crore, positive operating cash flow and a meaningful reduction in net working capital days. Exports grew 41 per cent and crossed ₹1,200 crore, with North America and Europe being the key markets. Net profit for Q4FY26 stood at ₹119 crore (up 67 per cent y-o-y) and ₹346 crore for FY26 (up 87 per cent). Among its various electronics manufacturing segments, automotive has grown by 39 per cent, industrial electronics by 30 per cent, healthcare by 36 per cent and consumer by just around 8 per cent. “That



It’s very tough to say [when the West Asia situation will be stable]. The present stalemate is not a solution. It will hurt everyone

JASBIR SINGH GUJRAL
MD, Syrma SGS Technology



[consumer business growth] is a conscious call because it’s a low-margin business,” said Gujral. With regard to focusing on original design manufacturing (ODM), Gujral says the company is

cautious about balancing profitability with investments for the future, and has been seeing good traction. Syrma SGS’ ODM revenue was 12 per cent of the total sales in FY25 and 17 per cent

in FY26. On the softening smartphone market, a poster boy for India’s EMS ecosystem, Gujral anticipates a ripple down effect on the components space. “We are not present in that supply chain; so, it does not directly impact us. But on a macro level, if the mobile phone industry sees a slowdown, it would have a ripple down effect on component manufacturing, plastics, sheet metal,” he said. “But I think it is early days. I am told the government is working out PLI-2 on mobile phones. It’s in the works. So, let’s see how it pans out,” he said. The company, which saw

some weakness in its share price on Tuesday, as it decided not to proceed with proposed acquisition of solar inverter maker K-Solare Energy Private Ltd, is now evaluating going the greenfield route. “We’ll set up a project; we’re negotiating, talking to the technology partners,” said Gujral. **UPCOMING PCB PLANT**
As for the company’s upcoming PCB manufacturing plant in Andhra Pradesh, construction slowed slightly over the last 40-45 days due to a labour shortage caused by the elections, but we are on track to begin trial production in the January-March quarter, he said.

Rift within AIADMK widens as faction led by Velumani and Shanmugham backs TVK

Our Bureau
Chennai

A group within the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), led by senior leaders SP Velumani and CV Shanmugham, on Tuesday announced support for the government headed by C Joseph Vijay, signalling internal unrest within the Dravidian party. Claiming the backing of around 30 MLAs, the group urged AIADMK General Secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami to convene a general council meeting to review the reasons behind the party’s consecutive electoral defeats. **NDA ALLIANCE**
Addressing reporters, Shanmugham said the party had contested the elections as part of the National Democratic Alliance but suffered defeat. “We accept this. We are now not part of the NDA.



CHANGING TRACK. AIADMK’s senior leaders SP Velumani (left) and CV Shanmugham (middle) address the media

We need to revive the AIADMK, and this is primary motive. We have decided to support the TVK government,” he said. Even as the announcement fuelled speculation over a possible split in the AIADMK, Velumani dismissed such suggestions and

appealed to the media not to portray the development as a breakthrough move. “We don’t have any plan to split the party. This is not our intention. Please don’t spread such news,” said Velumani. Meanwhile, senior AIADMK MLA Thalavai N

Sundaram, backing Palaniswami, said: “All statements given by CV Shanmugham are false. They want berth with the TVK. We will take legal action [if MLAs split]. We met the Speaker regarding many issues. We have given a list of MLAs to the Speaker. NDA alliance is intact.” On Monday, the group headed by Velumani met the pro-term Speaker MV Karuppiah with a letter of support of 30 MLAs, including Shanmugham and Vijayabaskar. The letter urged to make Velumani the AIADMK Legislature Party Leader. At the same time, a group of 17 MLAs loyal to Palaniswamy met Karuppiah and submitted their support to Palaniswami as leader of the AIADMK legislature party. Meanwhile, on Tuesday evening, Chief Minister Vijay had a meeting with the group headed by Shanmugham and Velumani.

AMMK expels lone MLA Kamaraj for backing TVK

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam (AMMK) expelled its lone MLA, S Kamaraj, for allegedly indulging in anti-party activities after he expressed support for Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) in the Tamil Nadu Assembly. Kamaraj was the only AMMK member in the 17th Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly. AMMK General Secretary TTV Dhinakaran said Kamaraj had violated the party’s stand by arbitrarily expressing support to the TVK during Assembly proceedings, which he said was against the party’s principles and objectives. Dhinakaran said Kamaraj’s actions amounted to a “great betrayal” of AMMK cadres, alliance parties and voters who had backed him.

In key bureaucratic reshuffle, Metro Rail MD Siddique appointed TN Finance Secy

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Tamil Nadu government on Tuesday effected a major bureaucratic reshuffle, with MA Siddique, Managing Director, Chennai Metro Rail Ltd, appointed as the new Finance Secretary. He will replace T Udhayachandran. Siddique, an IAS officer of Tamil Nadu Cadre belonging to the 1995 batch, had served in various capacities in the Tamil Nadu government and at the Centre. He has been working as Managing Director of CMRL since June 2022. He holds a bachelor’s degree in Technology in Electronics and Communications Engineering from the Indian Institute of Technology-Madras. Prior to CMRL, he was Commissioner of Commercial Taxes, between 2019 and 2021, and Commissioner of Revenue Administration from December



MA Siddique

2021. He held the post of Principal Secretary (Expenditure), Finance Department, between 2017 and 2019. In the Government of India, Siddique worked as Director in the Department of Expenditure for a year between 2008 and 2009, and worked in two key ministries of Home and Finance for five years between 2009 and 2014. **REVENUE ADMIN**
Meanwhile, former Chief Secretary N Muruganandam, on his return from leave, has been posted as Additional

Chief Secretary/Commissioner of Revenue Administration and Disaster Management, replacing P Amudha, who was holding additional charge. S Swarna, Principal Secretary/State Project Director, Rashtriya Uchchatar Shiksha Abhiyan, has been transferred and posted as Principal Secretary to the Government, Tourism, Culture and Religious Endowments Department, replacing K Manivasan, holding additional charge. The services of K Nanthakumar, Registrar of Cooperative Societies, have been placed at the disposal of the Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation (TASMAC) for appointment as its Managing Director, replacing T Christuraj, says a government order. A Annadurai has been appointed Secretary-III to the Chief Minister and V Vishnu was named Additional Secretary to the CM.

Delay in naming Kerala CM prompts IUML to convene emergency meet

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

The prolonged delay in naming a Chief Minister for Kerala following the United Democratic Front’s (UDF) electoral victory appears to have prompted the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), a key constituent of the alliance, to convene an emergency leadership meeting in Panakkad on Wednesday. Senior IUML leaders, including top State functionaries and national representatives, are expected to participate in the meeting. Discussions are likely to focus on the prevailing political uncertainty, its adverse impact on party workers, the possible implications for Cabinet formation, and the allocation of ministerial berths for the League.

While the IUML remains a major constituent of the Congress-led UDF, party leaders have warned that the delay in government formation is creating uneasiness and public concern. **DISSATISFACTION**
The leadership has reportedly conveyed its apprehensions to the Congress high command, cautioning that continued uncertainty could lead to dissatisfaction among party workers. IUML leaders said they were finding it increasingly difficult to respond to questions from the public regarding the formation of the government and the announcement of the Chief Minister. Technocrat MP Sukumaran Nair said the delay in naming a Chief Minister has created a governance deficit

and mounting administrative pressure. The absence of a designated leader has resulted in policy paralysis, stalling the implementation of the UDF’s proposed 100-day development programme, including the rollout of the five major guarantees announced by Congress leader Rahul Gandhi. “The anti-incumbency gains against the LDF could be eroded if the UDF appears incapable of providing decisive leadership at the very beginning of its term,” he said. The Congress high command appears to be handling the leadership issue in a manner similar to the compromise arrangements witnessed earlier in Karnataka and Rajasthan. He warned that the delay was creating an unprecedented governance deficit in the State’s 70-year legislative history.

Uber chief Dara calls on Cabinet Ministers to discuss future roadmap

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

With various policies on the anvil, including the Delhi Electric Vehicle (EV) policy and schemes in other States, ride-hailing company Uber’s Chief Executive Officer Dara Khosrowshahi is on a five-day visit to India, and met senior Cabinet Ministers on Tuesday to discuss the roadmap ahead. He met the Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, Consumer Affairs Minister Pralhad Joshi, Labour Minister Mansukh Mandaviya and others to discuss strategic investments and platform growth, sources said. He will also go to Bengaluru and Hyderabad where the company has tech centres. “When we last met in 2022, we made a promise. I’m proud to share we’ve



RICH CONVERSATION. Uber CEO Dara Khosrowshahi, along with a delegation, calls on Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in New Delhi on Tuesday

kept it — the number of earners on Uber’s platform in India has quadrupled since we last met. We had a rich conversation about Uber’s strategic investment roadmap for India and how platforms like ours can be genuine partners in the journey toward #ViksitBharat2047,” said Khosrowshahi in post on X after

meeting the Finance Minister. **STRONG MARKET**
Uber holds a strong market in India, with around 50 per cent share as of early 2026 in the ride-hailing segment, and is growing in double digits. The company is particularly strong in the premium and airport segments. Mean-

while, Pralhad Joshi said it was strongly emphasised that Uber India create an ecosystem to transition its existing fleet to EVs while building a support system for partners and drivers who are on board. “It was also communicated that self-auditing report on the existence of dark patterns and action taken report on such patterns need to be submitted at the earliest. As a convergence partner, Uber was advised to publish details of its Grievance Redressal Officer at the earliest and work towards timely resolution of complaints received on the National Consumer Helpline portal,” he added. Civil Aviation Minister Kinjarapu Ram Mohan Naidu, who also met the Uber chief, said it was a forward-looking discussion focused on enhancing the air travel experience through better and more convenient last-mile connectivity for passengers.

‘FORWARD LOOKING’
“It was a forward-looking discussion that focused on enhancing the air travel experience through better and more convenient last-mile connectivity for passengers. Alongside improving passenger convenience, I also encouraged the delegation to further strengthen sustainable mobility initiatives, in line with our broader vision of making urban transit cleaner and efficient,” said Naidu. Amitabh Kant, Ex-Sherpa, said that Uber’s journey in India is a testament to India’s sustainable mobility vision. “Uber is an example of not just serving India but create in India by building tech solutions out of world-class tech centres in India. Uber’s best chapter in India is still ahead,” Kant added.

Uttar Pradesh
Power Sector

Reliable Today • Empowering Tomorrow



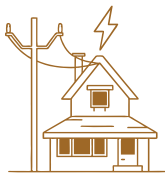
ADVERTISEMENT

POWERING
PROGRESS.
ENERGISING
UTTAR PRADESH.

A resilient power ecosystem.
A stronger tomorrow.

Behind thriving industries, productive farms, and aspirational homes lies a dependable energy backbone.

Uttar Pradesh has transformed its power ecosystem by expanding capacity, strengthening infrastructure, and ensuring reliable access, fueling rapid economic and social progress.



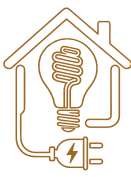
POWER THAT REACHES
EVERY CORNER

Ensuring dependable supply across urban and rural Uttar Pradesh



ROBUST
INFRASTRUCTURE

Expanding networks. Enhancing capacity. Building future-ready systems



ENERGY FOR
EVERY HOME

Lighting lives. Enabling aspirations.



POWERING
ECONOMIC GROWTH

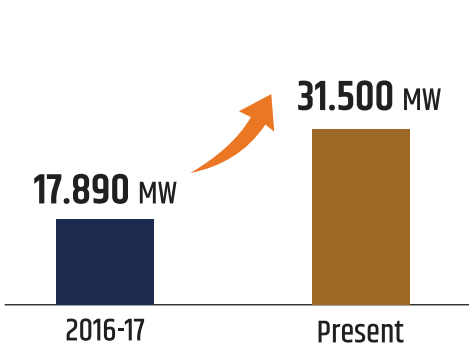
Reliable energy driving industry and growth

Strengthening Today.
Securing Tomorrow.

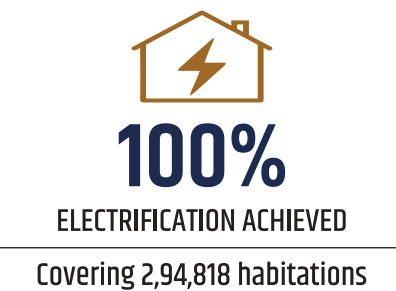
From generation to last-mile delivery, Uttar Pradesh is building one of India's most resilient power ecosystems.

Strategic investments, digital integration, and consumer-focused reforms are driving efficiency, reliability and trust.

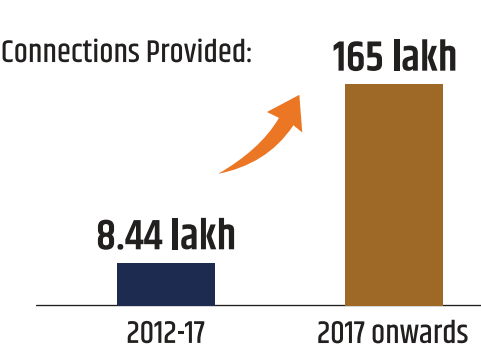
TRANSMISSION CAPACITY



ELECTRIFYING EVERY
HABITATION



CONSUMER CONNECTIONS



BUILT TO
DELIVER

- Distribution transformers increased to 27.9+ lakh units
- 765 new 33/11 KW substations constructed since 2017
- 2,455 substations upgraded for enhanced capacity



ENERGY FOR
FARMERS

- Free electricity support for private tubewells
- Over 2.42 lakh new agricultural connections (2022-25)
- Targeted irrigation support for Bundelkhand



Simple • Digital •
Seamless

- 'Jhatpat Portal' for new connections
- Online billing and payments
- Multi-channel rural service access



SMART SYSTEMS
LOWER LOSSES

- 56 lakh consumer meters and 2.19 lakh DT meters installed under the Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme.
- 1,24,210 circuit km of AB cable laid
- Line losses reduced to 13.77%
- 96% progress under RDSS



RELIABILITY
IMPROVED

Significant reduction in transformer failure rates, enhancing supply stability

Power Transformers Failures reduced from 1.96% (2024-25) → 0.68% (2024-25)

Distribution Transformers Failures reduced from 9.31% (2025-26) → 6.55% (2025-26)

*Up to November of respective years.



MORE CAPACITY
MORE CONFIDENCE

- Installed capacity has increased to 32.259 MW
- Total contracted capacity stands at 55.860 MW
- New thermal projects operationalised



MODERN CITIES.
STRONGER NETWORKS.

CM Grid Scheme projects underway in 14 major cities

Phase	Projects
Phase 1	76 Projects
Phase 2	42 Projects (Approved)



UTTAR PRADESH:
Electrifying Growth. Empowering Every Sector.

“ With a robust, future-ready power ecosystem, Uttar Pradesh is not only meeting today's energy demands but also building a strong foundation for sustained industrial growth, agricultural resilience, and improved quality of life. ”



Govt unveils Unified Bharat e-Charge

INNOVATION PUSH: The platform, like the UPI, aims to streamline EV charging availability across all States

Our Bureau
Mumbai

India on Tuesday unveiled what could become the electric-vehicle equivalent of UPI, as Union Heavy Industries Minister HD Kumaraswamy launched Unified Bharat e-Charge (UBC), a national platform that will allow EV users to locate, book and pay across charging networks operated by oil companies, state agencies and private charge point operators through a single interoperable interface.

The launch gives official shape to a “UPI for EV charging” framework that *businessline* first reported on May 10. Built by Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd (BHEL) and supported by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), the platform is designed as a “one nation, one app” system displaying real-time charger availability, ownership, power output and location.



CHARGING AHEAD. Heavy Industries Minister HD Kumaraswamy inaugurates the Conference on Enabling Nationwide EV Charging Infrastructure, on Tuesday ANI

“Just as UPI revolutionised digital payments, Unified Bharat e-Charge is set to revolutionise EV charging in India,” Kumaraswamy said at the National Conference on Enabling Nationwide EV Charging Infrastructure under the PM E-DRIVE scheme in Bengaluru.

REVOLUTIONISING EV
Heavy Industries Additional Secretary Hanif Qureshi said the next phase “is not about

how many chargers we install, but whether any EV owner can access any charger seamlessly.”

India’s planning benchmark is about 72,000 public chargers by 2030, including 44,000 for two- and three-wheelers, 26,000 fast chargers for passenger vehicles and 1,800 high-capacity chargers for buses and trucks.

Trucks account for just 3 per cent of vehicles on In-

dian roads but consume 42 per cent of the country’s diesel, making commercial vehicle electrification central to reducing oil imports.

So far, ₹503.86 crore has been sanctioned for 4,874 chargers under PM E-DRIVE across states and public sector enterprises including BPCL, Indian Oil and HPCL. Of 9,100 approved chargers, 6,200 have been energised, while around 1,800 are awaiting grid connectivity, highlighting utility connections as the principal bottleneck.

CENTRAL SUPPORT
Kumaraswamy also announced approval of 1,243 chargers in Karnataka with central support of ₹123.26 crore. The state has more than 8,600 charging stations, the highest in the country.

India currently has over 67,000 chargers, including private and captive installations, of which more than 25,000 are fast chargers. “You travel on these highways and you’ll find a charger

in less than 30 km,” Qureshi said.

Automakers said the focus is shifting from charger availability to reliability. “The questions are no longer around availability. Now the questions are around reliability, will the charger work when I reach there?” said Omkar A. Shaligram, Head of EV Charging & Ecosystem Development at Tata Motors and Tata Charge.

POLICY ATTENTION
Shaligram noted that nearly 90 per cent of EV charging still happens at homes and workplaces, while most policy attention remains focused on public charging. Tata Motors is advocating a statutory “right to charge” to allow apartment residents to install home chargers.

“If you want 30 per cent EV penetration in India, you have to solve for public charging and home charging. Solving only one will not get us there,” he said.

With inputs from Bengaluru bureau

Nominations window opens for bl Changemaker Awards 2026

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

It is time again to celebrate the everyday heroes in our midst who, through their selfless work, have changed lives and spaces for the better. The *businessline* Changemaker Awards 2026 is seeking nominations of those whose actions and deeds have left a lasting impact on our world.

If you know someone who is transforming your community or making a larger impact on society, nominate the person or organisation for the *businessline* Changemaker Awards 2026 today. The nomination window is now open.

We invite our readers to identify and nominate individuals or organisations that have ushered in meaningful social, digital, or financial transformation.

The Changemaker Awards were launched in 2018 on the 25th anniversary of *businessline*; seven editions of the awards have been held since then.

FIVE CATEGORIES
Nominations can be made across five categories of awards — Changemaker: Social Transformation; Changemaker: Digital Transformation; Changemaker: Financial Transformation; Young Changemaker and Iconic Changemaker.

One flagship award goes to the Changemaker of the Year, which is awarded to a person or an organisation that has ushered in far-reaching change.

THE PROCESS
Once the nomination window closes, the applications will be screened and evaluated by *businessline* along



with our knowledge partners (Deloitte and Ashoka). The shortlisted nominees will be validated by our validation partner (Niiti Consulting) before the list is sent to an independent jury to pick the winners in each category.

2025 WINNERS
In 2025, the Defence Research & Development Organisation (DRDO), counted among the world’s leading defence R&D organisations, was Changemaker of the Year.

The Iconic Changemaker of the Year award went to Azim Premji Foundation.

The Financial Transformation award was won by Araku Valley Coffee. The story is deeply intertwined with the Girijan Cooperative Corporation, an organisation established in 1956 to uplift Adivasi communities in the undivided Andhra Pradesh.

Recognising the coffee’s potential as a sustainable alternative to traditional shifting cultivation, the GCC launched coffee cultivation programmes in the Araku Valley in the early 1970s with the help of the Coffee Board.

The award for Digital Transformation went to Bhashini - National Language Translation Mission while the Social Transformation award was won by Impulse NGO Network. Hasina Kharrbhih, the pioneering

force behind Impulse NGO Network, founded it to tackle livelihood challenges faced by vulnerable communities in the eight north-eastern states of India. It has now grown into a globally recognised movement which addresses unsafe migration and human trafficking.

Kalyani Shinde, a young computer engineer from a farming family in Lasalgaon, solved the issue of detecting rotting onions in storage, a raging problem for farmers; and Vaishali Sharma & Anil Pradhan, who co-founded the Young Tinker Foundation to reimagine STEM education for students from financially humble backgrounds across India, were the joint winners of the Young Changemaker award.

The awards for 2025 were given away by Hardeep Singh Puri, Union Minister of Petroleum and Natural Gas.

Talking about the awards, Raghuvir Srinivasan, Editor, *businessline*, said, “The Changemaker Awards recognise the exceptional work done by individuals and organisations in transforming society. Most times, these individuals’ and organisations’ work flies under the radar. This is the gap that the award seeks to address.”

If you know of a Changemaker who needs to be celebrated, now is the time to send in your nominations.



NEET 2026 cancelled; new date to be notified soon

Our Bureau
New Delhi

India’s medical entrance test — NEET (UG) 2026 — held on May 3 was cancelled by the government on Tuesday amid allegations of paper leak and the CBI registering an FIR.

Even as the government said fresh dates would be notified in next 7-10 days, Opposition Congress and other parties came down heavily on the paper leak and demanded accountability.

The National Testing Agency (NTA), which conducts the NEET (Under Graduate) exam, said the decision to cancel the exam was taken in the interest of maintaining transparency and preserving trust in the national examination system.

The examination was conducted on May 3 across 551 cities in India and 14 cities abroad with 96.92 per cent turnout from nearly 23 lakh candidates.

MATTER OF CONCERN
The NTA statement said that the inputs received, taken together with findings shared

by law enforcement agencies, established that the present examination process could not be allowed to stand.

NTA’s Director General Abhishek Singh said: “paper leaks must end with immediate effect. It is unfortunate that we are at this stage. This is a matter of concern for the children of our country, for their parents, and for the entire ecosystem.”

Singh further said: “I understand that more than two lakh people were involved in the examination system. We take responsibility for what has happened. It was wrong. We are cancelling it and preparing to conduct it again with the assurance that such incidents will not be repeated.”

The CBI on Tuesday registered a case of criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust, theft and destruction of evidence under Bhatiary Nyay Sanhita, offences under Prevention of Corruption Act and under the Public Examination Prevention of Unfair Means Act 2024. It also sent multiple teams to various locations and coordinating with the



Protesters being detained by the police during a march against NEET-UG 2026 cancellation, in New Delhi on Tuesday ANI

Special Operations Group (SOG) of Rajasthan Police to collect materials.

ARRESTS MADE
The Rajasthan Police SOG had claimed that a ‘guess paper’ for chemistry was circulated among students ahead of the examination had approximately 410 questions and roughly 120 of these were in the question paper. In Nashik (Maharashtra), a man has been detained in connection with the paper leak.

The cancellation has triggered nationwide outrage among medical aspir-

ants as students took to social media questioning NTA’s competence and many even demanded the exam be conducted by AIIMS-Delhi.

The Opposition parties termed it administrative failure, insensitivity toward students and ‘repeated lapses’ in the conduct of competitive examinations. Student organisations affiliated with Congress and CPI(M) — NSUI and SFI held protests at several places.

OPPOSITION REACTS
Congress leader Rahul Gandhi targetted the government over the cancellation, saying Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s so-called ‘*amrit kaal*’ (nectar-filled era) has turned into a ‘*vish kaal*’ (poison-filled era) for the country.

Gandhi said: “The NEET 2026 examination has been cancelled. The hard work, sacrifices and dreams of more than 22 lakh students have been crushed by this corrupt BJP regime. Some fathers took loans, some mothers sold their jewellery, lakhs of children stayed up all night studying, and in re-

turn, they got paper leaks, government negligence, and organised corruption in education. This is not just a failure-it’s a crime against the future of the youth.”

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav also questioned the credibility of conducting the examination and asked what was the guarantee that papers won’t be leaked again if the test was re-conducted by same agency. AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal urged students to raise their voice on the issue. “I want to tell the students that they will have to come out on the streets. The AAP would stand with them. This government only understands the language of mass agitation,” Kejriwal said.

Trinamool Congress MP Sagarika Ghose alleged there was ‘zero accountability’ in the Modi government and accused it of being ‘incapable of daily administration’. CPI(M) MP John Brittas said repeated failures in national examinations were eroding public trust in the system. RJD working president Tejashwi Yadav also slammed the Centre.

Advertising council proposes risk-based labelling of AI ads

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

At a time when ad agencies and brands have begun dabbling with AI, the Advertising Standards Council of India (ASCI) has proposed guidelines for responsible labelling of such synthetically-generated content in advertising.

The self-regulatory body said the draft guidelines aim to ensure transparency while avoiding consumer-label fatigue. The draft guidelines are aligned with the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Amendment Rules (2026), it added. ASCI pushes risk-based norms for AI ads

The draft guidelines propose that the requirement to label AI-generated content in ads will be based on the risk it poses to consumers.

PURCHASE DECISIONS
Brands will need to assess whether AI use is central to an ad’s persuasive messaging or materially influences purchase decisions and whether it misleads consumers about the product’s claims, performance, or benefits.

Brands must also assess if the absence of a disclosure create a false impression of the product’s benefits.

ASCI has sought views from stakeholders and consumers till June 13 on the draft guidelines. Putting pro-

hibited content under high-risk category, the draft guidelines stated that high-risk ads are those that are illegal, infringe on rights, make misleading claims, or violate the ASCI code.

These will be found to be in violation of the ASCI code even if an AI label is used.

IDENTIFIABLE CUES
Fabricating endorsements, exaggerating product results or features through claims or visual representation, creating fake locations that appear realistic to the consumers, using deepfakes, copyrighted work or a person’s likeness without consent, using AI to generate fictional authority figures with identifiable cues, such as an AI-generated fake doctor promoting a supplement among others will be considered as high-risk ads.

“Medium-risk advertisements are those where AI use materially influences consumer decisions, and the lack of disclosure would mislead consumers. Labelling is mandatory in these cases to help consumers understand the nature of the representation,” it added. This includes instances such as using synthetically-generated influencers, replicating a real person’s likeness or voice even with their consent for personalised messaging, creating AI-generated exaggerated sound effects among others.

No ATF relief: AI may suspend few long-haul flights till Aug

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Tata Group-promoted Air India plans to temporarily suspend all flights to certain international destinations such as Chicago as elevated aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices continue to pressure overseas operations, industry sources told *businessline*.

The development comes amid indications that discussions between airlines and oil marketing companies (OMCs) on measures to ease international jet fuel prices failed to yield any material outcome.

When contacted, Air India did not respond to queries sent by *businessline*.

OPERATING COSTS
Speaking to *businessline*, sources pointed out that the proposal related to the crack spread mechanism for setting international ATF prices

has not been accepted by OMCs.

The absence of any immediate pricing relief sources said has increased pressure on airlines operating ultra-long and long-haul international sectors, where fuel costs account for a substantial portion of overall operating expenses.

A senior Air India executive said, on condition of anonymity, that the airline has been engaged in discussions on possible fuel pricing relief for several weeks.

“We have engaged with them for many weeks and discussed many options, but no material progress has been made so far and we cannot wait any longer, so yes, there will be some frequency cuts,” the official said.

Consequently, Air India is understood to have evaluated additional cuts across parts of its overseas network for June, July and August as part of a broader rationalisation exercise aimed at reducing



SCALING BACK. The proposed cut could impact more than 100 flights out of the over 1,100 daily services operated by the Air India Group

losses on unviable long-haul sectors.

According to industry insiders, apart from Chicago, the airline is also reviewing operational viability on other routes where profitability has come under pressure due to higher fuel prices and longer flying durations caused by airspace restrictions.

Notably, *businessline* was the first to report earlier this month that the airline had reduced flight frequencies

across several key international routes for May, with reductions of 5 per cent on some routes and up to 25 per cent on others.

In terms of this month’s flight rationalisation, North America operations were reduced by around 20 per cent, while frequencies on select European, Australian and Southeast Asian routes were moderated.

The sharpest reduction was seen in Australia, where services on the Melbourne

and Sydney routes were reduced, while select European destinations also witnessed lower frequencies as part of the network recalibration exercise. Besides, Southeast Asian operations were reduced by around 10 per cent during the month.

The combination of higher international jet fuel prices, along with geopolitical disruptions in West Asia, currency depreciation, and longer flying routes due to airspace restrictions, has significantly affected the profitability of long-haul international sectors, sources said.

PROLONGED CLOSURE
Furthermore, industry observers said that the prolonged closure of certain air corridors has increased block time on multiple routes, resulting in higher fuel burn, crew costs, and aircraft utilisation challenges for airlines operating international networks.

Last week, while address-

ing a townhall meeting at Air India headquarters here, Air India CEO Campbell Wilson said that the airline had undertaken rapid network optimisation to redeploy capacity more efficiently, strengthened its India-Europe and India-Far East presence, and deepened synergies with Air India Express by eliminating overlapping routes and improving network efficiency.

Meanwhile, industry sources said several airlines are increasingly focusing on preserving operational cash flows by prioritising routes that continue to generate sustainable demand and revenue visibility.

Globally too, airlines have undertaken selective international capacity rationalisation amid rising fuel prices and geopolitical uncertainty.

In addition, several foreign carriers have already announced frequency cuts or network adjustments across long-haul markets.

gious coercion between July 2022 and March 2026. One survivor also alleged false promises of marriage by one of the accused.

Regarding the charges, the NCW asked that the police further charge the accused for abuse of authority to coerce a woman.

Further, it asked that the complainants also be protected from undue media intrusion and anti-social elements.

